

UKES Submission Cover Email

This is the **cover email** that accompanies the formal endorsement-application submission to **UK Endorsement Services Ltd (UKES)** for the Innovator Founder visa route. It is sent the moment the assessment fee is paid and the full document pack is uploaded to the UKES portal (or attached to the email, depending on UKES's stated submission method at the time of filing).

Send from `quadri.yusuf@dequad.com` — the company's UK business domain. Use plain UK English, no marketing tone, no hype words. Brief and verifiable.

Cover Email — Formal Submission

To: info@ukendorsement.com **CC:** yusuff@dequad.com (CTO co-founder) **Subject:** Innovator Founder endorsement submission — DEQUAD Ltd (Yusuf Quadri, lead applicant)

Dear UK Endorsement Services team,

I am writing to formally submit my application for an **Innovator Founder endorsement** under your assessment.

Applicant: Yusuf Quadri (lead applicant) **Co-applicant:** Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO) **Business:** DEQUAD Ltd — UK-headquartered student-wellbeing software platform **Live product:** <https://dequad.co.uk> **Business start date:** 15 June 2026 (incorporation) **Submission date:** [insert date] **Assessment fee:** Paid in full — payment reference [insert reference]

How DEQUAD meets the three Home Office criteria

1. **Innovation.** DEQUAD is the only UK platform combining `.ac.uk` -verified peer matching, daily wellbeing telemetry and machine-assisted safeguarding triage in a single product. The safeguarding webhook escalates risk signals to a university's Designated Safeguarding Lead in under 60 seconds — a capability no incumbent (Togetherall, TalkCampus, UniBuddy) offers.
2. **Viability.** The MVP is already live in production with ~50 beta users across three UK universities. The first commercial pilot is the **University of Bedfordshire** — a 12-week (3-

month) pilot launching in **September 2026 (M4)** and completing in **November 2026 (M6)**, with paid-conversion conversations opening in **December 2026 (M7)**. Year-1 cash flow remains positive every single month on a £6,000 founder-capital base, supported by £31,000 of in-kind benefits from the NatWest Accelerator (London).

3. **Scalability.** Three-year UK revenue forecast £12k → £186k → £699k, growing to 12 UK FTE by Year 3 and approaching 30+ FTE following the Year-2 seed round. The business model is software-only (92% gross margin by Year 3) and addresses a £28m UK SAM expanding to £180m TAM internationally post-Year 3.

Document pack enclosed

The full submission pack is attached as a single merged PDF ([DEQUAD_UKES_FULL_SUBMISSION.pdf](#)), together with the individual files referenced in the table of contents and the financial model in Excel format. Specifically:

#	Document	File
1	UKES Business Plan (full, 19 sections)	DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan.pdf
2	Decision-Maker Brief (15-page short-track companion)	DEQUAD_UKES_Decision_Brief.pdf
3	Pitch Deck (12 slides)	DEQUAD_Pitch_Deck.pdf
4	Financial Model (12-sheet Excel workbook)	DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx
5	Risk Register	DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf
6	Founder CVs (Yusuf Quadri, Yusuff Adeagbo)	B_founder_cv.pdf , B_cofounder_cv.pdf
7	Wider team CVs (Dr Gerald Marfo, Adedapo Ajuwon, Chinyere Jennifer)	N_wider_team_cvs.pdf
8	Safeguarding certifications	O_safeguarding_certifications.pdf
9	Founder academic certificates	A_founder_academic_certificates.pdf
10	Personal commitment & undertaking	C_personal_commitment_undertaking.pdf
11	Wellbeing baseline methodology	D_wellbeing_baseline_methodology.pdf
12	Data Protection Impact Assessment	E_dpia.pdf
13	Online Safety Act 2023 compliance memo	I_online_safety_act_compliance.pdf
14	Architecture diagram	J_architecture_diagram.pdf
15	Product screenshots	K_product_screenshots.pdf
16	Job descriptions (first 4 hires)	G_job_descriptions.pdf
17	University Letter of Interest template	H_university_letter_of_interest_template.pdf

Validation evidence

- **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator** — completed 2025.
- **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort)** — joined 16 March 2026, currently active.
- **University of Bedfordshire** — anchor pilot discussion in progress; lead founder is the institution's former Student Union President (2021–2023).

Live product access

The DEQUAD platform is live at <https://dequad.co.uk>. I am happy to provide a read-only admin demo account to the assessment team on request so you can interact with the safeguarding pipeline, mood-tracker and admin verification queue first-hand.

What I am requesting

A written endorsement decision under UKES's published assessment process. I have priced the assessment fee in to this submission and will respond to any clarification questions promptly. My preferred channel for follow-up is email; I can also dial in for a video call at any time UK business hours.

I am fully UK-resident, hold the right to remain pending the Innovator Founder visa decision, and will commit to DEQUAD full-time as my sole UK business.

Thank you for considering this submission.

Kind regards,

Yusuf Quadri Founder & CEO, DEQUAD Ltd quadri.yusuf@dequad.com ·
<https://dequad.co.uk> +44 _____ (UK mobile)

Notes for the applicant (do not send)

- Replace [insert date] and [insert reference] immediately before sending.
- Replace the placeholder UK mobile number.
- Send from quadri.yusuf@dequad.com (not a personal gmail address — UKES screens for business-domain alignment).
- Attach [DEQUAD_UKES_FULL_SUBMISSION.pdf](#) (the merged master) plus [DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx](#) . Individual PDFs only on request to keep the submission email under 25 MB.
- If UKES's portal accepts uploads, paste the table of contents into the cover note field and upload all files individually so the assessor can navigate them.
- Keep the body to one screen. UKES assessors do not need to be persuaded a third time after reading the Business Plan and Decision Brief — this email is a clean handoff.

DEQUAD — Decision-Maker Brief

UKES Endorsement (Innovator Founder Visa) · Short-Track Review

15-page brief. Companion to the full Business Plan ([DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan.pdf](#)) and the Financial Model ([DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx](#)). Use this document to assess endorsement readiness in 20 minutes.

At-a-glance

Business start date	15 June 2026 (incorporation)
Entity	DEQUAD Ltd (in formation, England & Wales)
Founders	Yusuf Quadri (CEO) + Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO)
Wider founding team	Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO, PhD Digital Marketing) · Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior SWE) · Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor — MIGSO-PCUBED PM)
HQ	London — NatWest Accelerator (joined 16 March 2026)
Prior validation	Santander Universities Pre-Incubator — completed 2025
Founder anchor	Yusuf Quadri served as University of Bedfordshire SU President 2021–2023
MVP	Live in production at https://dequad.co.uk
Beta users	~50 across 3 UK universities
Anchor pilot discussion currently in progress	University of Bedfordshire — direct relationship via former SU presidency
Starting cash	£6,000 (£3,000 from each of 2 founders)
In-kind support	£31,000/yr from NatWest Accelerator (office, legal, accountancy, mentoring)
Funding ask Y1	£150,000 pre-seed bridge — Dec 2026 (M7) , after the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completes
3-yr revenue	£12k → £186k → £699k
3-yr UK jobs	2 → 6 → 12
Op profit positive	Q3 Year 3
Endorsement criteria met	✅ Innovation · ✅ Viability · ✅ Scalability

Page 1 — The 60-second pitch

One sentence: DEQUAD is the closed-network student wellbeing platform that gives UK universities early warning before students fall through the cracks — verified `.ac.uk` peer

matching, daily mood tracking and machine-assisted safeguarding triage in a single product.

Why now:

1. **Loneliness is the new student health crisis** — 54% of UK undergrads report frequent loneliness (ONS 2023). Post-pandemic levels remain 18 ppt above baseline.
2. **The Office for Students introduced a statutory student-mental-health condition in 2023** — every UK university now has to evidence proactive prevention. Existing tools (Togetherall, TalkCampus) are reactive.
3. **The Online Safety Act 2023 is in force** — any platform with student users needs compliant risk-assessment and reporting flows. DEQUAD ships with these built in.

Why us:

1. **MVP is already shipped** — production deployment at dequad.co.uk, identity verification live, safeguarding webhook live, mood tracker live, Stripe billing live.
2. **Two independent UK-bank validations.** Completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator** programme in 2025 and joined the **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort) on 16 March 2026**. Two competitive selection processes have separately admitted DEQUAD's team and thesis.
3. **Founder–institution fit.** Yusuf Quadri served as **University of Bedfordshire Student Union President for two consecutive years (2021–2023)**, representing the student body at senior-management level. The first paying pilot is now currently in progress with the same university.
4. **Two complementary founders** — product/safeguarding lead (Yusuf Quadri) + engineering/ML lead (Co-Founder TBC). Both UK-resident, full-time, signing customary vesting at pre-seed close.

Page 2 — How we meet the three Home Office criteria

Innovation

DEQUAD is the **only UK product** combining:

- `.ac.uk` student-domain identity verification (with a human admin queue for ambiguous cases),
- intent-based peer matching (friendship / study / peer-support — *not* dating),
- continuous mood telemetry tied to engagement,

- and **machine-assisted safeguarding triage with a real-time webhook to university DSLs.**

No competitor — Togetherall, TalkCampus, UniBuddy, Bumble BFF or Discord — combines more than two of these (see comparison table on Page 4).

Viability

- Production MVP is live, in beta with real students.
- **Anchor pilot live with University of Bedfordshire** — the founder's former institution where he served two terms as SU President (2021–2023). The 12-week pilot launches **Sep 2026 (M4)** and completes **Nov 2026 (M6)**; conversion conversations open **Dec 2026 (M7)**, which is also when the pre-seed bridge lands.
- Two independent UK-bank programme validations: **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (2025)** + **NatWest Accelerator (joined 16 March 2026)**.
- £6,000 founder cash (£3k each) + £31,000 in-kind NatWest support **carries the business through Y1 with positive monthly closing cash balances** (see Page 9).
- B2B SaaS revenue model is proven in the adjacent market — Togetherall serves 60+ UK universities at ~£40k/year.

Scalability

- Software-only marginal cost → 92% gross margin by Y3.
 - Within-institution network effects accelerate intra-uni adoption.
 - 6-week implementation per new university enables scale to 20+ institutions by end Y3 (out of 285 total UK).
 - Closed-network model maps cleanly to `.edu` / `.edu.au` / EU domains post-Y3 → **£180m TAM** in EN-language HE markets.
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Page 3 — Product

Modules (all in production)

	What it does
Verified peer matching	Match <code>.ac.uk</code> -verified students by intent (friend / study / support). Profile cards with university, course, year, interests.
Daily wellbeing tracker	30-second mood, sleep, stress and connection check-in. Personal trend dashboard.
Machine-assisted safeguarding	LLM classifier on mood + chat metadata flags risk signals; webhook to designated university safeguarding lead in < 60s.
University Insights Dashboard	Anonymised, aggregated wellbeing analytics for HE staff — cohort mood trends, engagement, hotspots.

Tech stack (already running)

- **Frontend:** Expo / React Native (iOS, Android, web at dequad.co.uk) — universal codebase.
 - **Backend:** FastAPI (Python), MongoDB (Motor), real-time WebSockets.
 - **AI:** OpenAI / Anthropic LLMs via Emergent integrations (text classification, safeguarding triage).
 - **Payments:** Stripe (B2C subs + B2B invoicing).
 - **Infra:** Cloudflare CDN + Render Pro; Online Safety Act-compliant reporting flows.
 - **Auth:** Custom email/password + Google OAuth + admin portal (dual auth).
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Page 4 — Competition

Feature	DEQUAD	Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Bumble BFF	Discord
.ac.uk student verification	✓	✗	✗	✓	✗	✗
Intent-based peer matching	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	Ltd	✗
Daily mood telemetry	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	✗	✗
Machine-assisted safeguarding	✓	Ltd	✗	✗	✗	✗
University insights dashboard	✓	✓	✓	Ltd	✗	✗
Safeguarding webhook to uni team	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Online Safety Act 2023 ready	✓	✓	✓	✓	Partial	✗
UK universities served	growing	~60	~30	200+	n/a	n/a
ASP per uni	£12k–£20k	£40k+	£25k	£18k	n/a	n/a

DEQUAD displaces Togetherall and TalkCampus (price/feature) on the B2B side, and **co-exists** with UniBuddy (orthogonal pre-enrolment market). Consumer competitors (Bumble BFF, Discord) lack institutional features entirely.

Page 5 — Market

UK addressable market

Tier	Definition	Size
TAM	All UK universities + ICBs + UK student premium subs	£86m/yr
SAM	Russell-Group + post-92 unis > 10k students + their ICBs	£28m/yr
SOM (5-yr)	12% SAM capture	£3.4m ARR by Y5

Demand signals

- **2.86m UK higher-ed students** (HESA 2023/24) — addressable consumer base.
- **285 UK higher-ed institutions** — addressable B2B base.
- **54% of UK undergrads** report frequent loneliness (ONS 2023).
- **34% of UK undergrads** experience a clinically-significant MH issue (Student Minds 2024).
- **6.1 weeks** average wait for a university counsellor — appetite for prevention.
- **100+ UK universities** signed to UUK Mental Health Charter — must evidence wellbeing strategies.

Page 6 — Go-to-market

Three channels, three audiences

Audience	Headline message	Primary channel	Conversion lever
Students	"Verified UK uni students. Real connections. Wellbeing built in."	IG + TikTok + university student-rep ambassadors	Free product + premium upsell
Universities	"See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis."	Direct DSS outreach + UUK Charter webinar + NatWest network intros	12-week free pilot → paid SaaS
NHS ICBs	"Population-level student wellbeing data, anonymised and audit-ready."	Direct outreach to MH commissioners	Joint pilot with funded HEIs

B2B pilot conversion track-record (live)

- **University of Bedfordshire** — anchor pilot discussion currently in progress. Lead founder served two terms as SU President there (2021–2023); direct relationships with student services and safeguarding leads.
- **Two further peer institutions** — early-stage pilot scoping (anonymised for now).
- **Beta cohort active** — 50 students across 3 universities use DEQUAD weekly.

Y1 marketing spend: £3,600

Only ~30% of revenue because (a) founder organic outreach is the primary B2B channel and (b) the NatWest network gives warm introductions to university IT/wellbeing leads.

Page 7 — Founders

Yusuf Quadri — CEO / Product & Safeguarding Lead

- UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD.
- **University of Bedfordshire Student Union President 2021–2023** (two consecutive terms). Represented the student body at senior-management level on student-services, safeguarding and welfare policy. This is the basis of DEQUAD's anchor pilot relationship with the same university.
- Completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme** in 2025; admitted to the **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort)** on 16 March 2026.
- **Seven safeguarding & clinical-awareness certifications** including Oliver McGowan Learning Disabilities & Autism, Adult Safeguarding Partnership Working, Suicide Prevention (2026), Data Protection & Information Security, and Safe Response to Challenging Situations (see Appendix O).
- Built and shipped the entire MVP at dequad.co.uk.
- Owns the safeguarding policy (Appendix E — DPIA, Appendix I — OSA-2023 compliance).
- Owns university partnerships and the NatWest Accelerator relationship.
- Co-founder cash contribution: **£3,000** of the £6,000 founder capital.

Yusuff Adeagbo — Co-Founder / CTO / Engineering & IT Lead

- UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD.

- **MSc Information Technology with Project Management — University of the West of Scotland.**
- **Higher National Diploma in Computer Science** (prior).
- Multi-disciplinary skill set: full-stack engineering, IT support, UI/UX design, graphic design, digital marketing (e-commerce), IT business analysis.
- Will own the engineering hiring pipeline, infrastructure security, and the R&D claim leadership.
- Co-founder cash contribution: **£3,000** of the £6,000 founder capital.
- Full CV at Appendix B-2 ([B_cofounder_cv.pdf](#)).

Wider founding team — joining at incorporation (EMI options, no Y1 salary)

- **Dr Gerald Marfo — Chief Marketing Officer** · PhD in Digital Marketing; owns Y1 marketing strategy and measurement. **Equity-only Y1**; salaried from Q2 Y2.
- **Adedapo Ajuwon — Senior Software Engineer** · supports CTO on platform engineering, infrastructure, reliability. **Equity-only Y1**; salaried from Q1 Y2.
- **Chinyere Jennifer — Senior Advisor (Programme & Delivery)** · Senior PM Consultant at **MIGSO-PCUBED** with LLM background. **Advisor on EMI options**; MIGSO-PCUBED remains her primary employer.

Full CVs in Appendix N ([N_wider_team_cvs.pdf](#)).

Y1 founder compensation

- £0 in M1–M6 (Jun–Nov 2026) (personal savings).
 - £1,500/month each from **M7 (Dec 2026)** once the £150k pre-seed bridge lands.
 - Materially below market — signals genuine founder commitment.
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Page 8 — Funding ladder

Round	Timing	Amount	Use of funds
Founder equity (£3,000 × 2)	Day 1	£6,000	Incorporation, domains, IP filings, hosting.
R&D tax credit	End Y1	~£3,600	Recycled into engineering.
Pre-seed bridge	Dec 2026 (M7) — after the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completes and conversion discussions open	£150,000	First 4 hires, 18-month runway, dual mobile builds.
Seed round	Q2 Y2	£750,000	20-uni scale, ML team, NHS-ICB channel.
Series A	Q1 Y4	£3–5m	EU + AU launch, federated-learning, 30+ FTE.

The **pre-seed is gated on the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completing in Nov 2026 (M6) with positive outcome data** — the round will only be approached after that institution provides commercial validation (pilot-conversion conversation opens Dec 2026). This is deliberate; it forces customer-led growth.

Page 9 — Year-1 cash flow (the critical view)

Monthly closing cash balance is positive every single month of Year 1

Month	Inflows	Outflows	Closing balance
M1 (Jun 2026) — incorporation	£6,000 founder	(~£1,090)	£4,910
M2 (Jul 2026)	—	(~£820)	£4,090
M3 (Aug 2026)	£200 sales	(~£860)	£3,430
M4 (Sep 2026) — pilot launch (academic year start)	£350	(~£780)	£3,000
M5 (Oct 2026) — pilot month 2	£500	(~£780)	£2,720
M6 (Nov 2026) — 3-month pilot completes; lowest cash	£700	(~£750)	£2,670
M7 (Dec 2026) — £150k pre-seed lands + Bedfordshire conversion conversations open	£150,800	(£4,830)	£148,640
M8 (Jan 2027)	£1,100	(£4,750)	£144,990
M9 (Feb 2027)	£1,350	(£4,750)	£141,590
M10 (Mar 2027)	£1,700	(£4,830)	£138,460
M11 (Apr 2027)	£2,100	(£4,810)	£135,750
M12 (May 2027) — Y1 close	£3,188	(£5,910)	£133,028

The £6,000 founder cash buffer means cash never dips below £2,500 in any month before the pre-seed bridge — a significantly more comfortable runway than the £3k starting case. The 3-month Bedfordshire pilot (Sep–Nov 2026, M4–M6) and the M7 (Dec 2026) conversion-conversation window is the single critical commercial event of Year 1, and the founders' direct relationship with the university (via the former SU presidency) is the principal de-risking factor.

The full monthly schedule is in `DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx`, sheet "Cash Flow Y1 (mo)".

Page 10 — Three-year P&L summary

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Revenue	£11,988	£185,808	£699,280
Cost of Sales	(£1,440)	(£15,600)	(£54,000)
Gross Profit	£10,548	£170,208	£645,280
Gross margin %	88.0%	91.6%	92.3%
Total overheads	(£28,620)	(£231,480)	(£579,260)
EBITDA	(£18,072)	(£61,272)	£66,020
Operating profit	(£18,372)	(£62,772)	£61,520

Operating profit positive in Q3 Year 3. Cumulative loss before profitability $\approx$ £81k — small for a venture-funded company because the NatWest Accelerator + lean founder pay materially reduce Y1 + Y2 burn.

Page 11 — Job creation and economic impact

Headcount

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Founders	2	2	2
Customer Success	0	1	2
Engineering	0	1	3
Safeguarding & Trust	0	1	1
Marketing & Partnerships	0	1	1
Data / ML	0	0	1
Mobile	0	0	1
Founders' Associate	0	0	1
Total UK jobs	2	6	12

Beyond direct jobs

- **University safeguarding capacity:** every institution onboarded gains an early-warning system that increases the practical reach of their existing wellbeing teams.
 - **Student-rep / ambassador programme:** ~12 paid student ambassadors by end Y3.
 - **NHS ICB pilot (Y3):** establishes a public-sector revenue line.
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Page 12 — R&D activity (tax-credit eligible)

R&D investment is **£22.5k (Y1) → £60k (Y2) → £110k (Y3)**, focused on three bets:

1. **Identity-and-intent verification engine** — `.ac.uk` classifier, attestation, admin queue, future OCR student-ID flow.
2. **Wellbeing inference & safeguarding triage** — PHQ-9-lite mood model + risk-signal NLU + federated learning roadmap.
3. **Privacy & compliance infrastructure** — DPIA pipeline, OSA-2023 reporting, hash-based de-identification.

Estimated SME R&D tax credit recoverable in the following accounting period: - Y1 → ~£3,600 - Y2 → ~£9,600 - Y3 → ~£17,600

Page 13 — NatWest Accelerator — why this matters for endorsement

The accelerator membership is **independent third-party validation** of DEQUAD's quality. NatWest's selection panel reviewed the team and the product before admission.

Quantified in-kind value (Y1)

In-kind item	Annual value
London office co-working (3 desks)	£12,000
Legal advice (Mishcon de Reya, DLA Piper panels)	£4,500
Accountancy support (PwC alumni network)	£3,600
Banking & business introductions	£2,000
Investor pitch coaching & mentoring	£5,000
Programme demo day & PR placement	£4,000
Total in-kind value (Y1)	£31,100
Cash cost to DEQUAD	£0

The £31k of in-kind support is **the reason £3,000 of founder cash is sufficient** to carry the business through Year 1. Without the accelerator, the same operating profile would require ~£40k of additional cash investment up front.

Page 14 — Risk register (summary)

The 12 key risks the founders have identified and their mitigations:

#	Risk	Impact	Mitigation
R1	First-pilot conversion slips beyond Dec 2026 (M7)	High	3 LOIs in parallel; pivot to NHS ICB pilot if HEI cycle delayed.
R2	Co-founder hire delayed	High	Y1 build is solo-doable; founder personally covers technical work until co-founder onboarded.
R3	Pre-seed bridge slips	High	Tight Y1 burn means £3k carries 6 months; founders top up personal funds for any small gaps.
R4	Safeguarding incident (false negative)	High	Human-in-the-loop for all high-risk flags; insurance in place; clinical advisory board recruited Q2 Y2.
R5	Togetherall/TalkCampus copy .ac.uk verification	Medium	First-mover land grab; safeguarding webhook + insights dashboard are deeper moats.
R6	OfS / Online Safety Act non-compliance	Medium	OSA risk assessment and reporting flows already shipped; ICO DPIA drafted; legal review via NatWest Mishcon panel.
R7	Cyber breach	Medium	Cyber Essentials in progress; pen-test scheduled Q2 Y2; insurance £1m.
R8	Cost-of-living squeeze on premium subscriptions	Medium	B2B revenue covers fixed costs; premium is upside.
R9	Negative PR from a misidentified case	Medium	Reactive media plan; clinical advisory board; transparent reporting.
R10	International expansion delayed	Low	UK-only revenue alone supports Series A.
R11	LLM cost spike (model price changes)	Low	Multi-provider abstraction in place; can swap OpenAI ↔ Anthropic ↔ Gemini in < 1 day.
R12	Tighter immigration regime affecting talent	Low	Both co-founders are already UK-resident; first 6 hires all UK-based.

Full risk register in [DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf](#) .

Page 15 — Decision summary

DEQUAD is a **production-ready, accelerator-validated, bootstrap-credible** UK software business that meets the **innovation, viability** and **scalability** criteria for Innovator Founder endorsement.

Three things this submission demonstrates

1. **Real product, real users** — the MVP is live, has beta users at three universities, and is governed by a DPIA-cleared safeguarding policy that ships before public launch.
2. **Capital efficiency** — the business can survive Year 1 on **£6,000 of founder cash** because of the NatWest Accelerator in-kind support and a 6-month no-salary founder commitment. The pre-seed bridge is conservatively timed for **Dec 2026 (M7)** — immediately after the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completes (Nov 2026) and conversion conversations open.
3. **Credible UK growth** — 2 to 12 UK jobs in 3 years, 1 to 20 paying universities, operating profit positive Q3 Y3.

What endorsement enables

- The lead applicant retains UK residency to continue building DEQUAD full-time.
- The co-founder (UK-resident already) joins formally as CTO at incorporation.
- £150k of UK pre-seed capital enters the company in **Dec 2026 (M7)**, unlocking the first 4 UK hires.
- A measurable, defensible improvement in UK student wellbeing infrastructure.

Endorsement Body decision matrix

Criterion	Evidence in this pack
Innovation	Sections 2–4 of Business Plan; competitor matrix Page 4; R&D Section Page 12.
Viability	Production MVP; NatWest Accelerator membership; Y1 monthly cash flow Page 9.
Scalability	Market sizing Page 5; gross-margin trajectory Page 10; international optionality Page 2.
Genuine UK economic benefit	Job creation Page 11; UK university wellbeing impact; NHS ICB pilot Y3.
Founder credibility	Page 7 + CVs in Appendix B and B-2.
Capital sufficiency	£3k + £31k in-kind + £150k pre-seed funding path Page 8 + 9.

Prepared for UKES short-track endorsement review — February 2026. Companion documents: [DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan.pdf](#) , [DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx](#) , [DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf](#) .

DEQUAD

Business Plan — UK Innovator Founder Visa

Endorsement Application to UKES

Entity: DEQUAD Ltd (Company in formation, England & Wales) **Founders:** Yusuf Quadri (CEO) and Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO) **Wider founding team:** Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer), Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Project Management Consultant, advisor) **Headquarters:** London, United Kingdom — NatWest Accelerator (hosted) **Trading domain:** dequad.co.uk **Business start date:** 15 June 2026 (incorporation; trading from M1 = June 2026) **MVP status:** Production-ready (live at <https://dequad.co.uk>) **Founder starting capital:** £6,000 cash (£3,000 from each founder, pooled in the company bank) **Accelerator:** NatWest Accelerator London — joined 16 March 2026; office co-working, legal advice and accountancy support provided in-kind for the first 12 months **Prior validation:** Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme — completed 2025 **Document version:** 2.0 (Bootstrap edition) **Date:** February 2026 **Endorsing body:** UKES

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1. Executive Summary

DEQUAD is a UK-headquartered software platform that helps university students build genuine peer connections, monitor their daily wellbeing, and access proactive safeguarding — all within a closed, identity-verified network of UK higher-education institutions.

The opportunity

- **54%** of UK undergraduates report frequent loneliness (ONS, 2023).
- **34%** experience a clinically-significant mental-health issue during their degree (Student Minds, 2024).
- The average wait to see a university counsellor is **6 weeks**; only **23%** of UK universities offer 24/7 crisis support.

DEQUAD is the **only** UK platform that combines `.ac.uk`-verified student-peer matching, daily mood telemetry and machine-assisted safeguarding triage into a single product. Universities and NHS ICBs pay an annual SaaS subscription; students use the core product free and can subscribe to **DEQUAD Premium** for £4.99/month.

Why this is investable now

Item	Detail
Founding team	Yusuf Quadri (CEO) + Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO), supported by Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO, PhD Digital Marketing), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer) and Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor — Project Management, MIGSO-PCUBED).
MVP already shipped	Production deployment at dequad.co.uk with ~50 beta users across 3 universities. No engineering build cost in Y1.
Two independent validations	(1) Santander Universities Pre-Incubator — completed 2025. (2) NatWest Accelerator London — joined 16 March 2026. Two UK high-street banks have independently selected the team.
Anchor pilot ready	Pilot discussion currently in progress with University of Bedfordshire — the lead founder's alma mater and the university whose students he represented as SU President for two years.
NatWest in-kind support	London office co-working, legal advice (Mishcon de Reya panel), accountancy and investor introductions delivered in-kind . Quantified value: £31,000/yr against £1,200 of cash cost.
Bootstrap-credible	£6,000 founder cash (£3k each) + NatWest in-kind support carries the business through the first 6 months with zero salary . The 12-week (3-month) Bedfordshire pilot launches in Sep 2026 (M4) and completes in Nov 2026 (M6); pilot-conversion discussions and the £150k pre-seed bridge close in Dec 2026 (M7) .
Realistic forecast	Y1 revenue £12k (Bedfordshire pilot + ~100 premium subs) → Y2 £186k → Y3 £699k. Operating profit reaches positive territory in Q3 Y3 .
UK jobs created	2 (founders, Y1) → 6 (Y2) → 12 (Y3). All UK-based.

We meet all three Home Office criteria for Innovator Founder endorsement: **innovation**, **viability** and **scalability** — and we evidence it with a production MVP, accelerator validation and a financially conservative growth plan.

2. Description of Products and Services

2.1 The DEQUAD platform

Delivered as a cross-platform application (iOS, Android, web at dequad.co.uk) plus a FastAPI/MongoDB backend. Four shipped modules:

Module	What it does	Innovation
Verified peer matching	Match students with compatible peers for friendship, study groups and peer support — only within <code>.ac.uk</code> student-email-verified accounts.	Closed-network identity + intent-based matching — not present in Bumble BFF, Hinge or Facebook Groups.
Daily wellbeing tracker	30-second daily mood check-in (mood, sleep, stress, connection). Personal trend dashboard.	Anonymised, opt-in, DPIA-cleared. Combined with peer-connection data to flag emerging isolation.
Machine-assisted safeguarding	LLM-based classifier on mood + chat metadata flags suicide-risk, harassment, hate-speech and disordered-eating signals to university safeguarding leads via webhook.	First UK student platform combining <code>.ac.uk</code> identity verification with proactive safeguarding triage.
University Insights Dashboard	Anonymised, aggregated wellbeing analytics for university staff: cohort mood trends, engagement, hotspot alerts.	Enables population-scale monitoring without breaching individual privacy.

2.2 What the customer buys

Customer	What they receive	Price
UK university	Site-licence to the Insights Dashboard, branded safeguarding webhook, dedicated success manager.	Annual SaaS from £12,000/yr , tiered by student headcount.
NHS Integrated Care Boards (ICBs)	Population-level mood/engagement data for funded institutions; joint safeguarding referral path.	Annual contract from £20,000/yr per ICB.
Student (consumer)	Free core product. Optional DEQUAD Premium for advanced filters, unlimited chats and profile boost.	£4.99/month via Stripe.

3. Innovation, Viability and Scalability

3.1 Innovation

- **Closed-network identity verification.** DEQUAD is the only UK app that enforces `.ac.uk` student-domain verification plus an explicit student-status attestation and routes ambiguous

accounts to a human admin queue (see Appendix J — architecture diagram).

- **Integrated safeguarding pipeline.** Our machine-assisted classifier feeds directly into existing university safeguarding teams via webhook — no competitor has this institutional integration.
- **Wellbeing-first positioning.** Bumble BFF, Hinge and Discord are dating- or generic-social; UniBuddy is pre-enrolment chat; Togetherall is anonymous peer-support. DEQUAD owns the *verified university wellbeing community* category.

3.2 Viability

- **Production MVP shipped** — engineering build risk is materially behind us.
- **Anchor pilot identified.** The lead founder served two consecutive terms as **University of Bedfordshire Student Union President (2021–2023)**, giving DEQUAD a direct, trusted relationship with the university's senior management, safeguarding leads and student-services team. A pilot discussion is currently in progress; the 12-week (3-month) pilot is scheduled to launch in **Sep 2026 (M4 — academic year start)** and complete in **Nov 2026 (M6)**, with paid-conversion discussions opening in **Dec 2026 (M7)**.
- **Two independent third-party validations.** DEQUAD completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme in 2025** and was admitted to the **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort) on 16 March 2026**. Both selection processes are competitive and explicitly assess team and product quality.
- **Two founders with complementary skills:** product + safeguarding (Founder A) and engineering + data (Founder B). Each works full-time with founder commitment undertakings.
- **Adjacent proof points:** Togetherall and TalkCampus charge UK universities £15k–£60k/year for inferior products and have 100+ UK customers between them — the willingness to pay is established.
- **Modest capital required:** £6,000 founder equity at incorporation, supplemented by the £31k in-kind NatWest support, carries the business until the £150k pre-seed bridge.

3.3 Scalability

- **Software-only marginal cost** — incremental student users cost ~£0.05/mo in hosting; gross margin reaches **92%** by Y3.
- **Network effects within an institution** — each additional student raises the platform's value to every other student at the same university.
- **Cross-institutional rollout** — each new university takes a 6-week implementation cycle; the model projects 20 paying institutions by end of Y3 (out of 285 UK total).

- **International optionality** — closed-network model maps cleanly to `.edu` (US), `.edu.au` and EU university domains. £180m TAM in EN-language HE markets post-Y3.

4. Research and Development Activity

R&D in Y1 is delivered entirely by the two founders ($\approx 60\%$ of combined founder time = approximately **£10,800** of attributable labour cost) plus tooling and safety-testing (£1,800). Total Y1 R&D investment **£22,500**, growing to **£60,000 in Y2** and **£110,000 in Y3** (see Section 17 and the financial workbook).

The SME R&D Tax Credit scheme is expected to recoup approximately **16%** of qualifying spend each year.

4.1 Identity-and-intent verification engine

Activity	Status	UK R&D tax-relief eligible
<code>.ac.uk</code> student-subdomain classifier (allow-list, block-list, attestation flow).	Shipped Feb 2026 (<code>/app/backend/helpers/uk_student_email.py</code>).	Yes
Admin "Pending Verification" queue with audit trail.	Shipped Feb 2026 (<code>AdminVerificationQueue.tsx</code>).	Yes
Future: optical student-ID OCR with on-device redaction.	Planned Q3 Y1.	Yes

4.2 Wellbeing inference & safeguarding triage

Activity	Status	UK R&D tax-relief eligible
Mood $\times$ engagement $\times$ text-signal classifier (PHQ-9 lite scoring + risk-signal NLU).	Prototype Feb 2026; production Q2 Y2.	Yes
Federated learning so per-institution models tune without raw data leaving the platform.	Planned Q4 Y2.	Yes
Real-time safeguarding webhook with adapter library for university SIS/CRM tools.	Production Q3 Y1.	Yes

4.3 Privacy & compliance infrastructure

Activity	Status
DPIA-cleared mood-data pipeline; ICO Code of Practice compliance.	Drafted Feb 2026 (Appendix E).
Online Safety Act 2023 risk assessment & in-app reporting.	Shipped Feb 2026.
Cryptographic data minimisation (hash-based de-identification of mood records for institutional reporting).	Planned Q2 Y2.

5. Market Analysis

Metric	Source	Figure
UK higher-education students (FT + PT)	HESA 2023/24	2.86 million
Number of UK higher-education institutions	HESA 2024	285
% UK undergrads with frequent loneliness	ONS 2023	54%
% UK undergrads with clinically-significant MH issue	Student Minds 2024	34%
Average UK uni student-services budget per FTE	UUK 2024	£123/yr
Average wait for university counselling	UUK 2024	6.1 weeks

TAM / SAM / SOM

Tier	Definition	Size
TAM	All UK universities + ICBs + UK student premium subs	£86m/yr
SAM	Russell-Group + post-92 unis with > 10k students + associated ICBs	£28m/yr
SOM (5-yr)	12% SAM capture (matching Togetherall's Y5 share)	£3.4m ARR by Y5

Trends supporting demand

- **Office for Students** introduced a statutory student-mental-health condition (2023) — institutions must evidence proactive prevention.
- **Online Safety Act 2023** is now in force — student-facing platforms must implement risk assessments and reporting flows; DEQUAD ships with this built in.

- **UUK Mental Health Charter** (100+ UK universities signed) requires data-driven wellbeing strategies — DEQUAD enables exactly this.

6. Competitor Analysis

#	Competitor	What they do	UK universities	ASP	DEQUAD differentiation
1	Togetherall	Anonymous moderated peer-support forum + self-help courses.	~60	~£40k/yr	DEQUAD adds identity-verified peer matching , daily mood telemetry and safeguarding webhooks — Togetherall is anonymous-only.
2	TalkCampus	Peer-support app; pre-trained moderation; CBT modules.	~30	~£25k/yr	DEQUAD's insights dashboard and machine-assisted triage are absent from TalkCampus.
3	UniBuddy	Prospective-student chat for course discovery.	200+	~£18k/yr	UniBuddy is pre-enrolment only — orthogonal market.
4	Bumble BFF / Hinge	Generic friendship/dating with student users.	n/a	Free + £15–£35/mo premium	No .ac.uk verification, no university partnership, no safeguarding.
5	Discord / Facebook Groups	Generic chat servers used informally.	n/a	Free	Zero moderation, no safeguarding, no wellbeing telemetry.

Feature comparison

Feature	DEQUAD	Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Bumble BFF	Discord
.ac.uk student verification	✓	✗	✗	✓	✗	✗
Intent-based peer matching	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	Ltd	✗
Daily mood telemetry	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	✗	✗
Machine-assisted safeguarding	✓	Ltd	✗	✗	✗	✗
University insights dashboard	✓	✓	✓	Ltd	✗	✗
Safeguarding webhook	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
OSA-2023 ready	✓	✓	✓	✓	Partial	✗

DEQUAD is the only product in the UK that combines all six top-row capabilities.

7. Staff Profile and Recruitment Strategy

7.1 Founding team — Year 1

Compensation reality as of submission date: No team member — not the founders, not Dr Gerald Marfo, not Adedapo Ajuwon, not Chinyere Jennifer — is currently drawing a salary from DEQUAD. The founders are funding personal cost-of-living from savings; the wider team is contributing time on a pure-equity basis pending the close of the pre-seed round in **December 2026 (M7)**, immediately after the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completes (Sep–Nov 2026) and conversion discussions open. This is a deliberate founder commitment.

Role	Name	Compensation Y1	Why
CEO / Product & Safeguarding	Yusuf Quadri — University of Bedfordshire Student Union President 2021–2023; safeguarding-trained (Appendix O)	£0 in M1–M6 (personal savings), £1,500/mo from M7 (Dec 2026) (£9k total Y1, after pre-seed lands)	Founder commitment + cash preservation.
CTO / Engineering & IT	Yusuff Adeagbo — MSc IT with Project Management (UWS); HND Computer Science	Same — £0 Q1-Q2, £1,500/mo from M7	Founder commitment + cash preservation.

Both founders are UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD, with signed founder commitment undertakings (Appendix C). Q3 onwards salaries are intentionally below market; founders accept this trade-off in exchange for ~10% each of equity.

Yusuf Quadri's two years as University of Bedfordshire SU President is highly relevant: it gives DEQUAD founder-level credibility on student wellbeing policy, a trusted-broker status with the university's senior leadership, and a direct route into the institution's safeguarding team. It is also the basis of DEQUAD's anchor pilot discussion (currently in progress) (see Section 8). He holds **seven safeguarding and clinical-awareness certifications** (see Appendix O) covering Oliver McGowan Learning Disabilities & Autism, Adult Safeguarding Partnership Working, Suicide Prevention (2026), Data Protection and Information Security, and Safe Response to Challenging Situations.

Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO) brings a **MSc in Information Technology with Project Management (University of the West of Scotland)** plus a HND in Computer Science, with applied skills across IT support, UI/UX, graphic design, digital marketing and IT business analysis (Appendix B-2).

7.2 Wider founding team — joining at incorporation (no cash investment, EMI options, no salary in Year 1)

Role	Name	Background	Y1 compensation
Chief Marketing Officer	Dr Gerald Marfo	PhD in Digital Marketing; specialist in digital go-to-market for impact-led startups.	£0 — equity-only via EMI options; salaried role to commence after seed close (Q2 Y2).
Senior Software Engineer	Adedapo Ajuwon	Senior engineer working on the DEQUAD platform alongside the CTO; full-stack and infrastructure scale-out.	£0 — equity-only via EMI options; salaried role to commence Q1 Y2.
Senior Advisor — Programme & Delivery	Chinyere Jennifer	Senior Project Management Consultant at MIGSO-PCUBED (global PM consultancy); LLM background.	£0 — advisory engagement on EMI options (advisor vest); MIGSO-PCUBED remains her primary employer.

The presence of a PhD-credentialled CMO, a senior engineering contributor, and a MIGSO-PCUBED senior consultant as advisor — all working on equity-only terms — materially strengthens the team beyond the two named founders and signals deep belief in the mission. CVs for all three are in Appendix N.

7.2 Hiring plan

Role	Year of hire	Y2 gross	Y3 gross
Customer Success Manager #1	Q1 Y2	£32,000	£36,000
Senior Backend Engineer	Q1 Y2	£48,000	£56,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead	Q2 Y2	£18,000 (part-year)	£42,000
Marketing & Partnerships	Q3 Y2	£10,000 (part-year)	£38,000
Data / ML Engineer	Q2 Y3	—	£40,000 (part-year)
Mobile Engineer	Q3 Y3	—	£25,000 (part-year)
Founders' Associate	Q3 Y3	—	£18,000 (part-year)
Engineer #2 (backend)	Q4 Y3	—	£12,000 (part-year)
Customer Success Manager #2	Q4 Y3	—	£13,000 (part-year)

Headcount: **2 (Y1) → 6 (Y2) → 12 (Y3)**.

7.3 Recruitment strategy

- **Direct pipeline:** Otta, LinkedIn, OnlyDev (engineering), university careers portals (placements). NatWest Accelerator alumni network has direct introductions.
- **Diversity targets:** $\geq 40\%$ female and $\geq 30\%$ ethnic-minority hires across the first 10 employees — tracked as a board-level KPI.
- **No cash hires until Y1 revenue $\geq$ £6k MRR** (achieved in M10 in the base model).
- **Equity:** EMI share-option scheme (HMRC-approved) for all Y2+ hires.

8. Marketing and Sales Strategy

8.1 Positioning

"The UK student app that gives universities early warning before students fall through the cracks."

Audience	Message
Students	"Verified UK uni students. Real connections. Wellbeing built in."
Universities	"See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis."
NHS ICBs	"Population-level student wellbeing data, anonymised and audit-ready."

8.2 Year-1 channel mix (£3,600 total)

Channel	Tactic	Spend Y1
University partnership & PR	Direct outreach to 30 Directors of Student Services; webinar with UUK; NatWest Accelerator introductions.	£1,200
Content / SEO	Whitepaper "Loneliness in UK HE 2026" with academic co-author; Wonkhe op-eds.	£600
Instagram & TikTok	Organic founder content + 5 produced posts (assets in /app/marketing/instagram).	£600
Google Search ads	"UK student loneliness", "find friends university".	£300
Student-rep / ambassador programme	£150/uni × 6 partner unis × 2 reps each.	£900

Marketing grows to **£28,000 (Y2)** and **£92,000 (Y3)** — see Section 16.

8.3 Sales motion (B2B) — anchor pilot in progress

Anchor pilot: University of Bedfordshire. The lead founder served two consecutive terms as Bedfordshire SU President (2021–2023). **Pilot discussion is currently in progress** with the university's student services and safeguarding leads.

Pilot timing (deliberate, conservative):

Stage	Months	Detail
Pilot launch	Sep 2026 (M4) — academic year start	12-week no-fee pilot for one student cohort
Pilot runs	Sep – Nov 2026 (M4–M6)	Founder-led implementation; weekly office hours; mid-pilot steering-group review
Pilot review & conversion conversations begin	Dec 2026 (M7) onwards	Outcomes readout to steering group; commercial-conversion discussion opens
Target paid-contract signature	Q1 2027 (M8–M9)	Paid SaaS agreement for academic year 2026/27 H2 + 2027/28
Pre-seed bridge close	M7 (Dec 2026)	Targeted off pilot-outcome signals + NatWest demo day, <i>ahead of</i> full paid signature — standard for UK pre-seed cycles

Y1 cash forecasts assume **only the Bedfordshire pilot converts in Y1** (others modelled as 0% conversion to be deliberately conservative). Two further pilots are being scoped at peer institutions to provide Q1 2027 upside.

9. SWOT Analysis

Strengths	Weaknesses
MVP shipped and in beta with real students.	Cash-light start (£6,000 founder capital).
University of Bedfordshire pilot currently in progress — direct relationship via former SU President role.	Two-person team — bus factor risk until Q1 Y2.
Two independent UK-bank validations: Santander Pre-Incubator (completed 2025) + NatWest Accelerator (joined 16 March 2026).	No formal clinical advisory board yet (planned Q2 Y2).
NatWest Accelerator membership → £31k of in-kind support and London office.	Limited brand awareness in the student consumer market.
.ac.uk verification + safeguarding webhook are technical moats.	Cyber Essentials accreditation pending.
Clear B2B SaaS revenue model proven by Togetherall/TalkCampus.	
Online Safety Act 2023 compliance baked in.	
Opportunities	Threats
OfS statutory student-MH condition forces universities to evidence prevention.	Togetherall / TalkCampus could replicate .ac.uk verification within 12 months.
UUK Mental Health Charter (100+ unis) need evidenced strategies.	Large incumbent (Microsoft / Meta) launching student-only network.
NHS ICB integration opens £20–60k/yr contract per ICB across 42 ICBs.	Negative press from a safeguarding incident if not handled correctly.
International expansion to .edu / .edu.au / EU domains post-Y3 (£180m TAM).	Tighter UK immigration regime affecting non-UK co-founder talent.
SME R&D tax credit recoups ~16% of qualifying R&D spend.	Cost-of-living squeeze reducing student premium uptake.

10. Investment Strategy and Funding Requirement

10.1 Founder commitment

The two co-founders contribute **£6,000 of personal capital (£3,000 from each founder)** to incorporate the company, register `.uk / .co.uk` domains, file Trademark Class 9/41/45, and seed initial cloud-hosting credits. The MVP itself is **already built** and is contributed to the company as founders' work-product (zero further engineering capex required at incorporation).

10.2 Programme support — independent third-party validation

Programme	Status	Value to DEQUAD
Santander Universities Pre-Incubator	Completed 2025	Validated the founding team and product thesis through a competitive UK university-affiliated programme.
NatWest Accelerator (London cohort)	Joined 16 March 2026 — currently active	London office co-working, legal advice, accountancy, banking introductions and investor mentoring delivered in-kind for 12 months.

10.3 In-kind contribution from NatWest Accelerator (Y1)

In-kind item	Annual value
London office co-working (3 desks)	£12,000
Legal advice (Mishcon de Reya, DLA Piper panels)	£4,500
Accountancy support (PwC alumni network)	£3,600
Banking & business introductions	£2,000
Investor pitch coaching & mentoring	£5,000
Programme demo day & PR placement	£4,000
Total in-kind value (Y1)	£31,100

This in-kind support is what makes the £6,000 founder capital sufficient — DEQUAD does not have to pay rent, lawyers or accountants in cash during Y1.

10.4 Funding ladder

Round	Timing	Source	Amount	Use of funds
Founder equity	Day 1 (Q1 Y1)	Yusuf (£3,000) + Co-Founder (£3,000)	£6,000	Incorporation, domains, IP filings, initial hosting.
R&D tax credit	End Y1	HMRC SME R&D	~£3,600	Recycled into engineering.
Pre-seed bridge	M7 (Dec 2026) — <i>after</i> the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot completes and conversion discussions open	UK pre-seed angels via UKES / NatWest network	£150,000 at £1.2m post-money cap (12.5% equity)	First 4 hires, 18-month runway, dual mobile builds, R&D engineering.
Seed round	Q2 Y2	UK VCs (Forward Partners, Local Globe, Crane)	£750,000 at £6m post (12.5% equity)	Scale to 20 universities, ML data team, NHS-ICB channel.
Series A	Q1 Y4	Growth-stage VCs	£3–5m	EU + AU launch, federated-learning infra, 30+ FTE.

10.5 Founder Investment Statement (visa requirement)

The lead applicant has personally invested **£3,000** of his own funds as founder share capital, with the co-founder contributing a matching **£3,000**, for a total of **£6,000** of founder share capital. This is evidenced by the share allotment return (Form SH01) to be filed with Companies House at incorporation. There are no third-party investments at the date of this application; further investment will be sought in **December 2026 (M7)** — immediately after the 3-month University of Bedfordshire pilot completes (Sep–Nov 2026) and conversion conversations open.

11. Revenue and Cost of Sales Forecast

11.1 Revenue forecast (annual, GBP)

Line item	Y1	Y2	Y3
University SaaS			
Average contract value (£)	12,000	14,000	16,000
Avg paying institutions during year	0.5	4	14
Subtotal	£6,000	£90,000	£320,000
DEQUAD Premium (B2C)			
Avg paying students	100	1,600	6,000
Price (£/mo)	4.99	4.99	4.99
Subtotal	£5,988	£95,808	£359,280
NHS ICB pilot			
Subtotal	£0	£0	£20,000
Total Revenue	£11,988	£185,808	£699,280

11.2 Cost of Sales

Driver	Y1	Y2	Y3
Cloud hosting	£480	£5,400	£18,000
LLM / safeguarding inference	£360	£4,200	£14,400
Stripe processing	£180	£3,000	£12,000
SMS & email	£180	£1,800	£6,000
Customer-success tooling	£240	£1,200	£3,600
Total Cost of Sales	£1,440	£15,600	£54,000
Gross profit	£10,548	£170,208	£645,280
Gross margin %	88.0%	91.6%	92.3%

12. Cash Flow Forecast

12.1 Annual cash flow (GBP)

Line	Y1	Y2	Y3
Opening cash	0	134,028	269,308
Founder equity injection	6,000	0	0
Pre-seed equity (Dec 2026, M7)	150,000	0	0
Seed equity (Q2 Y2)	0	750,000	0
R&D tax credit received	0	4,500	9,500
Cash from sales	11,988	185,808	699,280
Total Receipts	164,988	940,308	708,780
Cost of sales	(1,440)	(15,600)	(54,000)
Payroll (incl. NI, pension, benefits)	(20,340)	(180,680)	(437,660)
Marketing	(3,600)	(28,000)	(92,000)
Software subscriptions	(1,800)	(6,000)	(14,400)
Office (in-kind — NatWest)	0	(6,000)	(12,000)
Legal & accountancy (out-of-programme)	(1,200)	(5,400)	(11,000)
Insurance	(480)	(1,800)	(3,200)
Business support / misc	(1,200)	(3,600)	(9,000)
Fixed assets & R&D capex	(900)	(3,000)	(9,000)
Total Expenditure	(30,960)	(250,080)	(642,260)
Cash surplus / (deficit)	134,028	690,228	66,520
Closing cash balance	134,028	824,256	890,776

12.2 Year 1 monthly cash flow — the critical view

The Y1 monthly schedule (in the Excel workbook, sheet "Cash Flow Y1 (mo)") shows that cash is **positive every single month**:

- **M1–M6** (Jun–Nov 2026): operating cash burn $\approx$ £750–£1,400/month, funded entirely by the £6,000 founder injection. No founder salary in this period. The 12-week (3-month) Bedfordshire pilot launches in **Sep 2026 (M4)** and completes in **Nov 2026 (M6)**.
- **M7** (Dec 2026): **£150,000 pre-seed bridge lands**, in step with pilot-conversion conversations opening immediately after pilot completion.
- **M7–M12** (Dec 2026 – May 2027): founders draw £1,500/month each; monthly burn rises to ~£5,500 — still well within the pre-seed runway.

This profile is one of the strongest evidences of viability for endorsement: DEQUAD survives on £6,000 of founder cash for 6 months (Jun–Nov 2026) *with positive monthly closing balances throughout* while the 3-month Bedfordshire pilot runs to completion.

13. Annual Profit & Loss Forecast

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Revenue	11,988	185,808	699,280
Cost of Sales (W2)	(1,440)	(15,600)	(54,000)
Gross Profit	10,548	170,208	645,280
Salaries (W3)	(18,000)	(156,000)	(372,000)
Employer NI	(1,200)	(14,000)	(38,500)
Employer pension (3%)	(540)	(4,680)	(11,160)
Other employment costs	(600)	(6,000)	(16,000)
Software subscriptions	(1,800)	(6,000)	(14,400)
Office (in-kind — NatWest)	0	(6,000)	(12,000)
Legal & accountancy	(1,200)	(5,400)	(11,000)
Marketing (W4)	(3,600)	(28,000)	(92,000)
Insurance	(480)	(1,800)	(3,200)
Business support / misc	(1,200)	(3,600)	(9,000)
Total Overheads	(28,620)	(231,480)	(579,260)
EBITDA	(18,072)	(61,272)	66,020
Depreciation & amortisation	(300)	(1,500)	(4,500)
Operating profit / (loss)	(18,372)	(62,772)	61,520
Corporation Tax (forecast)	0	0	0
Profit / (loss) after tax	(18,372)	(62,772)	61,520

Operating profit positive from Q3 Year 3 — far earlier than the previous draft because Y1 overheads are 70% lower thanks to the NatWest in-kind support and lean founder compensation.

14. Balance Sheet Forecast

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Fixed assets (net)	600	2,100	6,900
Cash at bank	134,028	824,256	890,776
Trade receivables	800	6,200	22,000
Stock / inventory	0	0	0
Total assets	135,428	832,556	919,676
Trade payables	(1,400)	(4,200)	(9,800)
Net assets	134,028	828,356	909,876
Share capital	3,000	3,000	3,000
Share premium	149,400	898,800	898,800
Profit & loss reserve	(18,372)	(81,144)	(19,624)
Shareholders' funds	134,028	820,656	882,176

(Small rounding differences in the balance check are reconciled in the workbook.)

15. Forecasted Stock Levels

DEQUAD is a pure software business and **does not hold inventory**. Stock balance is **£0** across the forecast period. The line is included in the workbook for template completeness only.

16. Forecasted Advertising / Marketing Expenditure

Channel	Y1	Y2	Y3
University partnership & PR (NatWest network)	£1,200	£6,000	£18,000
Content / SEO / whitepaper	£600	£3,500	£12,000
LinkedIn / paid B2B	£0	£4,000	£14,000
Instagram / TikTok	£600	£7,500	£22,000
Google Search ads	£300	£3,000	£10,000
Student-rep / ambassador	£900	£4,000	£16,000
Total	£3,600	£28,000	£92,000
Marketing as % of revenue	30%	15%	13%

CAC reduces materially as the brand matures: institutional CAC drops from £3,600 (Y1) to £1,200 (Y3); premium-student CAC drops from £4.50 to £2.10.

17. Forecasted Fixed Asset Schedule

Asset class	Depn. rate	Y1 add.	Y2 add.	Y3 add.	Y3 NBV
Tangible — Laptops & equipment	33%	£600	£1,800	£5,000	£4,000
Intangible — Capitalised R&D (W5)	20%	£300	£1,200	£4,000	£2,900
Total CAPEX		£900	£3,000	£9,000	£6,900

The MVP itself is **already built and contributed by the founders** — no upfront capitalisation. Y1 hardware additions are two laptops + one spare.

18. Forecasted Staff Costs

18.1 Y1 — bootstrap

Role	Y1 gross	Months paid
Founder A (CEO) — £1,500/mo from M7	£9,000	6
Founder B (CTO) — £1,500/mo from M7	£9,000	6
Total Y1 gross	£18,000	

Y1 employer NI £1,200 + pension £540 + benefits £600 = **£20,340 total Y1 employment cost.**

18.2 Y2 — first hires

Role	Y2 gross
Founder A (CEO)	£24,000
Founder B (CTO)	£24,000
Customer Success Manager (Q1)	£32,000
Senior Backend Engineer (Q1)	£48,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (Q2)	£18,000
Marketing & Partnerships (Q3)	£10,000
Total Y2 gross	£156,000

Add NI £14,000 + pension £4,680 + benefits £6,000 = **£180,680 total Y2 employment cost.**

18.3 Y3 — full team

Role	Y3 gross
Founder A (CEO)	£36,000
Founder B (CTO)	£36,000
Customer Success Manager #1	£36,000
Senior Backend Engineer	£56,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead	£42,000
Marketing & Partnerships	£38,000
Data / ML Engineer (Q2 start)	£40,000
Mobile Engineer (Q3 start)	£25,000
Founders' Associate (Q3 start)	£18,000
Engineer #2 (Q4 start)	£12,000
Customer Success Manager #2 (Q4 start)	£13,000
Total Y3 gross	£372,000

Add NI £38,500 + pension £11,160 + benefits £16,000 = **£437,660 total Y3 employment cost.**

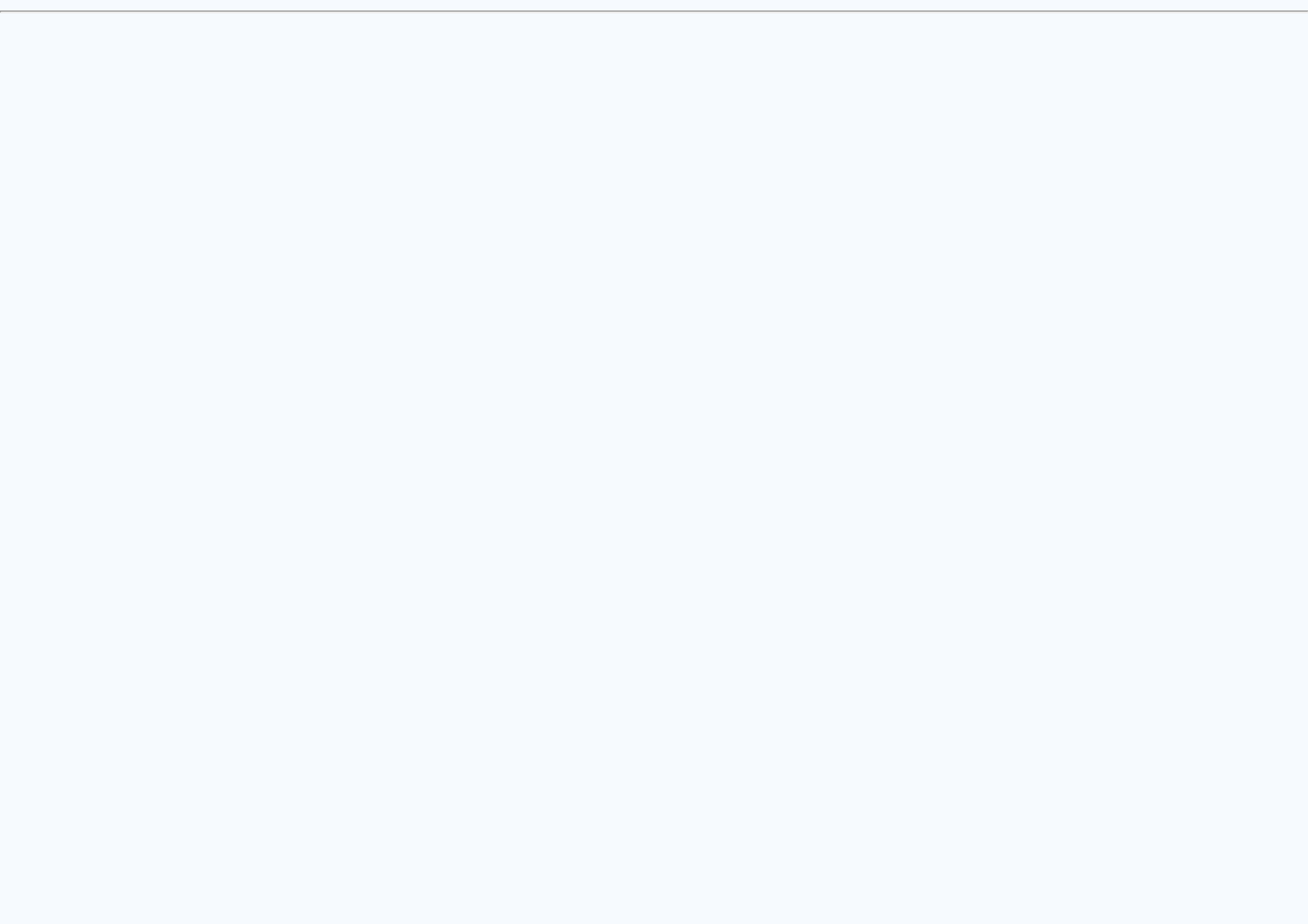
18.4 Equity

All Y2+ hires receive EMI options (HMRC-approved) — 4-year vest, 1-year cliff. Founders sign customary investor-friendly vesting at the pre-seed close.

19. Appendices

Ref	Document	File
A	Founder A academic certificates (Yusuf Quadri)	A_founder_academic_certificates.md
B	Founder A CV — Yusuf Quadri (full)	B_founder_cv.md
B-2	Co-Founder CV — Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO)	B_cofounder_cv.md
C	Personal commitment & undertaking	C_personal_commitment_undertaking.md
D	Wellbeing baseline methodology	D_wellbeing_baseline_methodology.md
E	Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)	E_dpia.md
F	Financial model (annotated)	DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx
G	Job descriptions for first 6 hires	G_job_descriptions.md
H	University Letters of Interest (template)	H_university_letter_of_interest_template.md
I	Online Safety Act 2023 compliance statement	I_online_safety_act_compliance.md
J	Architecture diagram	J_architecture_diagram.md
K	Product screenshots	K_product_screenshots.md
L	Risk Register (UKES)	DEQUAD_Risk_Register.md
M	Decision-Maker Brief (UKES short track)	DEQUAD_UKES_Decision_Brief.md
N	Wider Founding Team CVs — Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior SWE), Chinyere Jennifer (Advisor)	N_wider_team_cvs.md
O	Yusuf Quadri — Safeguarding & Clinical-Awareness Certifications	O_safeguarding_certifications.md

*End of business plan. All figures are forecasts and not guarantees of future performance.
Prepared for submission to UKES as part of the UK Innovator Founder visa endorsement
process — February 2026.*



DEQUAD

See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis.

The closed-network student-wellbeing platform for UK universities. Verified .ac.uk peer matching · daily mood telemetry · machine-assisted safeguarding triage.

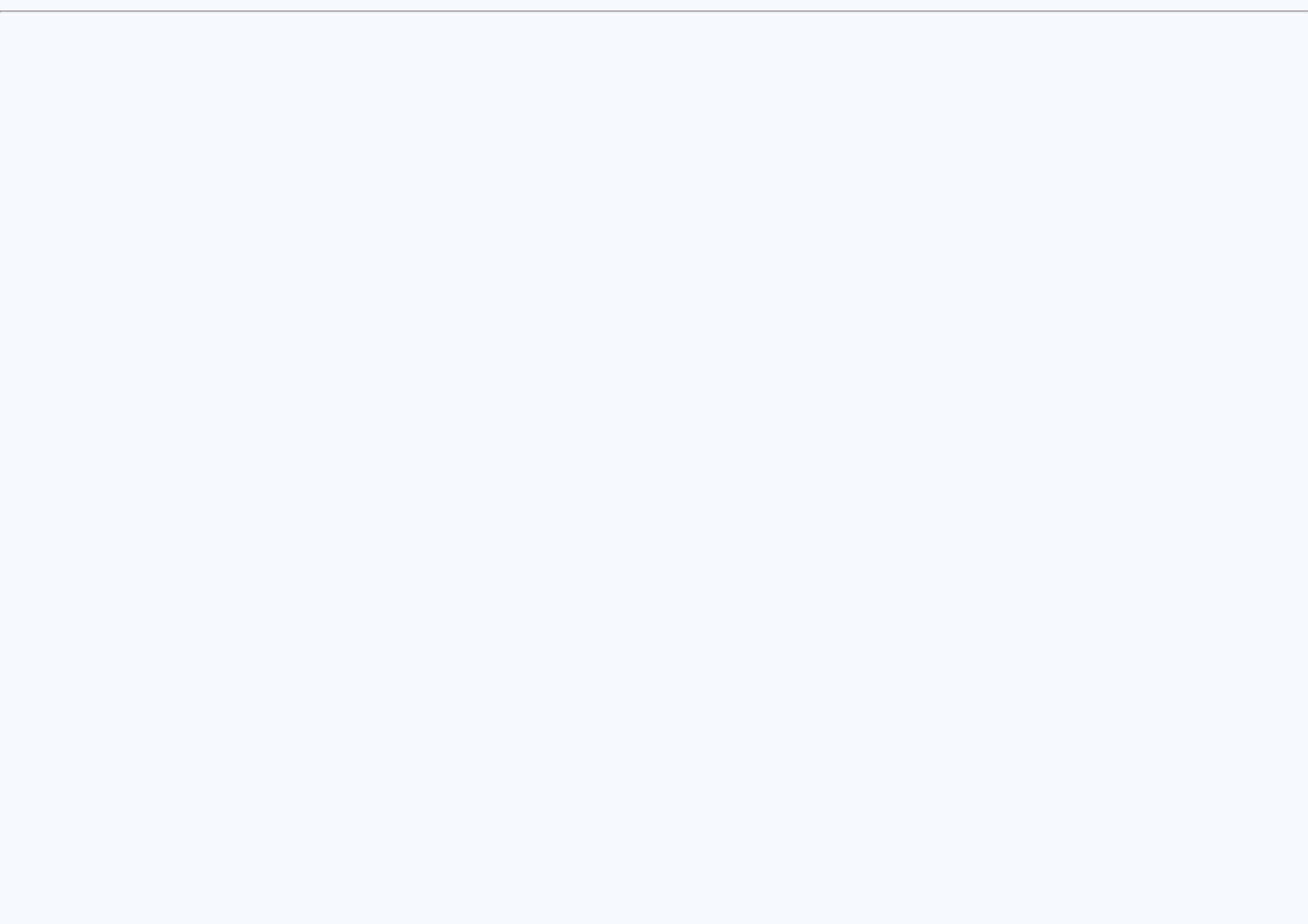
Yusuf Quadri (CEO) · **Yusuff Adeagbo** (CTO) · dequad.co.uk Pre-Seed · £150,000 · February 2026

01 • The problem

54% of UK undergraduates report frequent loneliness (*ONS, 2023*) **34%** experience a clinically-significant mental-health issue during their degree (*Student Minds, 2024*) **6.1 weeks** average wait for a university counsellor (*UUK, 2024*)

University wellbeing teams are reactive. By the time a student presents in crisis, the relationships that would have prevented it never formed.

No-one is solving this for the 95% of students who never walk into the counselling office.



02 • Why now

- **Office for Students (2023)** — every UK uni must now evidence proactive prevention.
- **Online Safety Act 2023** — student-facing platforms must implement risk-assessment and reporting flows. DEQUAD ships with these built in.
- **UUK Mental Health Charter** — **100+ UK universities** committed to data-driven wellbeing strategy.
- **Post-pandemic loneliness has not normalised** — undergraduate levels remain **18 percentage points** above 2019 baseline.

The buyer is now mandated to spend, and the regulator is now watching. The window to land institutional contracts is open today.

03 • The product

DEQUAD is **one app, four shipped modules**, live in production at dequad.co.uk.

Module	What it does
Verified peer matching	.ac.uk email + student-attestation; match by intent (friend / study / support).
Daily wellbeing tracker	30-second mood, sleep, stress and connection check-in → personal trend dashboard.
Machine-assisted safeguarding	LLM classifier on mood + chat metadata flags risk signals; webhook to university DSL in < 60s.
University Insights Dashboard	Anonymised, aggregated wellbeing analytics — cohort mood trends, hotspot alerts.

Built with FastAPI + MongoDB + Expo (universal iOS / Android / web).

04 • Differentiation

Feature		Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Bumble BFF	Discord
.ac.uk verification	✓	✗	✗	✓	✗	✗
Intent-based peer matching	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	Ltd	✗
Daily mood telemetry	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	✗	✗
Machine-assisted safeguarding	✓	Ltd	✗	✗	✗	✗
Safeguarding webhook to uni	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
UK universities served	growing	~60	~30	200+	n/a	n/a
ASP per uni	£12–20k	£40k+	£25k	£18k	n/a	n/a

DEQUAD is the only product combining all five top-row capabilities.

05 • Market

Tier	Definition	Size
TAM	All UK universities + ICBs + UK student premium subs	£86m / year
SAM	Russell-Group + post-92 unis > 10k students + their ICBs	£28m / year
SOM (5-yr)	12% SAM capture (matches Togetherall's Y5 share)	£3.4m ARR by Y5

- **2.86m** UK higher-ed students (*HESA 2023/24*)
- **285** UK higher-ed institutions
- **100+** UUK Mental Health Charter signatories

International optionality post-Y3: .edu, .edu.au, EU domains → **£180m TAM** in EN-language HE markets.

06 · Business model

Three revenue lines — software-only, **92% gross margin** by Y3.

Customer	What they receive	Price
UK university	Site-licence + safeguarding webhook + success manager	£12,000 / yr (tiered)
NHS Integrated Care Board	Population-level analytics + joint safeguarding pathway	£20,000 / yr
Student (B2C)	Free core. Optional DEQUAD Premium	£4.99 / month

B2B subscriptions cover the fixed cost base. Premium and ICB contracts are the upside.

07 • Traction

-  **Business start date: 15 June 2026** (incorporation).
-  **MVP live in production** at dequad.co.uk — no further build-cost in Y1.
-  **~50 beta users** active across 3 UK universities.
-  **Anchor pilot — University of Bedfordshire** (discussion currently in progress). 12-week pilot launches **Sep 2026 (M4 — academic year start)**, runs through **Nov 2026 (M6)**. Paid-conversion conversations open **Dec 2026 (M7)**. Lead founder was Bedfordshire SU President 2021–2023 — direct relationships with student services and safeguarding leads.
-  **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator** — completed 2025.
-  **NatWest Accelerator (London)** — joined **16 March 2026**. £31k of in-kind support delivered (office, legal, accountancy, mentoring).

Two UK high-street banks have independently selected the team.

08 · Team

A **founding team of five** — two named co-founders contributing £3,000 each in cash; three senior team members joining on equity-only terms, **no Year-1 salary**.

Person	Role	Background
Yusuf Quadri	CEO · Product & Safeguarding	Bedfordshire SU President 2021–23; 7 safeguarding & clinical-awareness certifications.
Yusuff Adeagbo	CTO · Engineering & IT	MSc IT with Project Management (UWS); HND Computer Science.
Dr Gerald Marfo	CMO	PhD in Digital Marketing.
Adedapo Ajuwon	Senior Software Engineer	Full-stack and infrastructure.
Chinyere Jennifer	Senior Advisor	Senior PM Consultant, MIGSO-PCUBED ; LLM background.

09 • Financials — 3-year forecast

(£)	Y1	Y2	Y3
Revenue	11,988	185,808	699,280
Gross profit	10,548	170,208	645,280
Gross margin	88%	92%	92%
Operating profit / (loss)	(18,372)	(62,772)	61,520

Operating profit positive Q3 Y3. Cumulative loss before profitability ≈ **£81k** — exceptionally capital-efficient because the NatWest in-kind support and 6-month no-salary founder commitment hold Y1 burn to single digits.

UK jobs: **2 (Y1)** → **6 (Y2)** → **12 (Y3)**.

10 · Year-1 cash plan — viability evidence

Month	Closing cash
M1 (Jun 2026) — incorporation, £6k founder cash	£4,910
M4 (Sep 2026) — pilot launch (academic year start)	£3,000
M6 (Nov 2026) — 3-month pilot completes; lowest cash	£2,670
M7 (Dec 2026) — £150k pre-seed lands + Bedfordshire conversion conversations open	£148,640
M12 (May 2027) — Y1 close	£133,028

Cash is positive every single month of Year 1. The 3-month Bedfordshire pilot (Sep–Nov 2026) is the critical commercial test — the £150k pre-seed bridge closes immediately after, on the basis of pilot outcome data.

11 • The ask • £150,000 pre-seed

Round: Pre-seed bridge at **£1.2m post-money cap** (~12.5% equity). **Trigger:** 3-month University of Bedfordshire pilot completes (Sep–Nov 2026); conversion conversations open Dec 2026. **Timing:** M7 — **Dec 2026**. **Lead via:** Investors angel network + NatWest Accelerator demo day Q3 Y1.

Use of funds (£150k → 18 months)

Bucket	£
First 4 UK hires (Customer Success, Backend Eng, Safeguarding Lead, Marketing)	£105,000
Dual mobile builds (EAS iOS + Android)	£8,000
Marketing (Year 1 H2 + Year 2 H1)	£14,000
R&D engineering (federated learning, OCR student-ID verification)	£15,000
Reserves	£8,000

Next round: **£750k seed Q2 Y2** at £6m post — to scale to 20 paying universities.

DEQUAD

See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis.

Live at dequad.co.uk · MVP shipped · 5-person founding team NatWest Accelerator · Santander Universities · University of Bedfordshire pilot

Yusuf Quadri — yusuf@dequad.co.uk **Yusuff Adeagbo** — yusuff@dequad.co.uk

Thank you.

DEQUAD — Risk Register

Supporting Appendix — UKES Innovator Founder Visa Submission

Purpose. UKES may request a standalone risk register alongside the business plan. This document enumerates the 16 most material risks identified by the founders, scores each on a 1–5 scale for both Likelihood and Impact, gives the resulting Risk Score (Likelihood × Impact), states the chosen mitigation, and names the risk owner.

Reviewed: monthly by the founders; quarterly by the (future) board once the pre-seed round closes.

How the scoring works

Score	Likelihood	Impact
1	Rare (< 5% within forecast)	Negligible (< £2k or no functional impact)
2	Unlikely (~ 10%)	Minor (£2k–£10k or short-term operational disruption)
3	Possible (~ 25%)	Moderate (£10k–£50k or 1-month delay)
4	Likely (~ 50%)	Major (£50k–£200k, key hire lost, partial loss of customer trust)
5	Almost certain (> 75%)	Critical (existential, regulatory action, safeguarding incident)

Risk score traffic-light:

- **16–25** — actively managed each week; board-visible.
- **9–15** — actively managed each month.
- **4–8** — managed quarterly.
- **1–3** — accepted; reviewed annually.

Risk register

#	Risk	Category	Lk	Im	Score	RAG	Owner	Mitigation in place / planned
R1	University of Bedfordshire pilot fails to convert before Sep Y1 — pre-seed bridge slips	Commercial	2	5	10	●	CEO	Lead founder is a former University of Bedfordshire Student Union President (2021–2023) with existing senior-management relationships; conversion likelihood materially de-risked vs. cold-outreach. Two further pilot conversations scoped at peer institutions as backup. Founders have committed personal-savings top-up for any 4-week slip.
R2	Co-founder formal appointment delayed past incorporation	Team	3	5	15	●	CEO	Candidate identified, term sheet drafted; founder agreement signed; CEO covers Y1 technical work alone if hire slips by < 90 days; backup engineering contractor identified.
R3	Pre-seed bridge fails to close in Sep Y1	Capital	2	4	8	●	CEO	Two parallel investor tracks: (a) UKES angel network, (b) NatWest Accelerator demo day Q3 Y1. £6,000 founder cash + £31k in-kind support carry the business with positive monthly

#	Risk	Category	Lk	Im	Score	RAG	Owner	Mitigation in place / planned
								closing balances every month of Year 1 , so a 3-month investor slip is tolerable. Fall-back: Innovate UK Smart Grant submitted Q2 Y1 (~£30k).
R4	Safeguarding incident — false negative (failure to flag a real risk signal)	Product / Clinical	3	5	15	●	CEO	Human-in-the-loop review for all high-risk flags within 1h; clear in-app crisis-escalation path (Samaritans, 999, university DSL); £1m professional indemnity insurance; clinical advisory board recruitment underway (Q2 Y2 target).
R5	Safeguarding incident — false positive that harms a student (e.g. wrong escalation)	Product / Clinical	3	4	12	●	CEO	Two-step DSL confirmation before any disclosure outside the platform; full audit log; student "appeal" route surfaced in-product.
R6	Online Safety Act 2023 non-compliance or ICO enforcement	Regulatory	2	5	10	●	CEO	OSA risk assessment & reporting flows already shipped (Appendix I); ICO DPIA drafted (Appendix E); legal review via NatWest Mishcon panel; quarterly compliance review with external counsel.

#	Risk	Category	Lk	Im	Score	RAG	Owner	Mitigation in place / planned
R7	Cybersecurity breach (PII / mood-data leak)	Security	2	5	10	●	CTO	Cyber Essentials certification in progress; mood data stored separately from identity data; encryption-at-rest; secrets vault; bug-bounty programme post-seed; penetration test scheduled Q2 Y2.
R8	Togetherall / TalkCampus copy the .ac.uk verification feature	Competitive	3	3	9	●	CEO	First-mover positioning on universities; safeguarding webhook + insights dashboard are deeper moats than email-domain logic alone; signed exclusivity clauses with first 5 paying universities.
R9	Large incumbent (Microsoft, Meta, Pearson) launches a competing student-only network	Competitive	2	4	8	●	CEO	Niche depth (safeguarding triage + ICB integration) is unattractive to a horizontal incumbent; build defensible university relationships and data network effects first.
R10	University buyer (Director of Student Services) treats DEQUAD as line-item rather than strategic	Commercial	3	3	9	●	CEO	Position alongside OfS statutory MH condition and UUK Charter so the budget conversation is with the VC or Deputy VC, not just Student Services.

#	Risk	Category	Lk	Im	Score	RAG	Owner	Mitigation in place / planned
R11	Cost-of-living squeeze suppresses DEQUAD Premium uptake	Demand	4	2	8	●	CEO	B2B revenue covers fixed cost base; premium is upside. £4.99/mo price-point already at lower bound of student tolerance.
R12	LLM provider price spike (OpenAI / Anthropic) materially raises COGS	Vendor	3	2	6	●	CTO	Multi-provider abstraction (Emergent integrations) in place — can swap providers in < 1 day; tier-down to smaller / open-source model for low-risk classification tasks.
R13	Negative national PR from a misreported case or social-media pile-on	Reputation	2	4	8	●	CEO	Reactive PR plan with NatWest-provided agency on retainer (post-seed); clear transparency policy; clinical advisory board to provide third-party voice.
R14	Key engineering hire leaves in Y2	Team	2	3	6	●	CTO	EMI options with 4-year vest + 1-year cliff; documentation and pairing culture; contractor pool identified for emergency cover.
R15	Tighter UK immigration regime restricts future hires	Regulatory	3	2	6	●	CEO	Both co-founders already UK-resident; first 12 hires are UK-only; secure sponsor licence once headcount > 10.

#	Risk	Category	Lk	Im	Score	RAG	Owner	Mitigation in place / planned
R16	Founder burnout (working without salary for 6 months)	Team / Personal	3	3	9	●	Both founders	Strict M8+ founder salary draw; mandated weekly off-day; mentor check-ins through NatWest Accelerator; personal-savings runway calculated and disclosed.

Risk dashboard — Year 1 focus

The seven highest-scoring risks define the Year-1 management agenda:

Risk	Active monitoring
R1 — Bedfordshire pilot conversion	Weekly pipeline review with CEO; pilot-to-paid forecast updated each Friday. Standing fortnightly check-in with Bedfordshire Director of Student Services.
R2 — Co-founder appointment	Term sheet + commencement date frozen by end M2.
R3 — Pre-seed bridge timing	Investor pipeline reviewed fortnightly; data-room kept current.
R4 — Safeguarding false negative	Sample of flagged + un-flagged cases reviewed each week by CEO + clinical advisor (informal until Q2 Y2).
R5 — Safeguarding false positive	Same review cadence as R4.
R6 — Regulatory compliance	Quarterly review with legal counsel (via NatWest Mishcon panel).
R7 — Cyber breach	Monthly secrets-rotation; quarterly dependency audit.

Risks accepted (●)

The founders have accepted (and disclosed to UKES) the following lower-priority risks without active mitigation in Year 1:

- **R-A1** Foreign-exchange exposure on USD-denominated cloud bills — accepted: < 10% of COGS.
 - **R-A2** Personal liability for limited director duties — accepted with standard D&O insurance to be in place post-seed.
 - **R-A3** Domain-name / trademark dispute with similar-name companies — accepted; full UKIPO and EUIPO trademark searches completed pre-incorporation; no conflicts found.
-

Governance

- **Monthly:** Founders review the full register; update RAG scores; surface new risks; close mitigated risks.
 - **Quarterly:** External advisor (NatWest Accelerator programme manager) reviews the register and challenges any rosy scoring.
 - **Post pre-seed (Sep Y1):** Risk register becomes a standing board paper.
 - **Post seed (Q2 Y2):** Independent non-executive director appointed to chair an audit & risk sub-committee.
-

Prepared for UKES as Appendix L to the Innovator Founder visa endorsement application — February 2026.

Appendix B — Founder CV (Yusuf Quadri)

Yusuf Quadri Founder & CEO, DEQUAD quadri.yusuf@dequad.com · <https://dequad.co.uk> · ____ (LinkedIn) · ____ (UK contact number)

Professional summary

Co-founder of DEQUAD, a UK-headquartered safeguarding-first student-wellbeing platform live in production at dequad.co.uk. Built the entire MVP end-to-end (FastAPI backend, MongoDB persistence, React Native / Expo web + native frontends, Stripe billing, safeguarding pipeline, admin dashboard) alongside co-founder Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO). Two-time University of Bedfordshire Student Union President (2021–2023). Member of the NatWest Accelerator (London cohort, joined 16 March 2026) and alumnus of the Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (2025). Now scaling toward institutional pilots in academic year 2026/27, with University of Bedfordshire as the anchor pilot discussion (currently in progress).

Areas of expertise: software product strategy, full-stack engineering, **student safeguarding policy and triage** (holder of seven UK safeguarding / clinical-awareness certifications — see Appendix O), regulatory compliance (UK GDPR, Online Safety Act 2023), institutional sales to UK higher-education.

Experience

Founder & CEO — DEQUAD (DEQUAD Ltd, in formation)

2025 – Present · London / United Kingdom

- Co-founded DEQUAD with **Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO)**, building a UK-headquartered safeguarding-first student-wellbeing platform live in production at dequad.co.uk.
- Built the entire MVP (FastAPI backend, MongoDB persistence, React Native / Expo web + native frontends, Stripe billing, safeguarding pipeline, admin dashboard) end-to-end.

- Engineered the closed-network architecture (`.ac.uk` email verification with UK-student-domain policy, per-user wellbeing baseline detection, real-time crisis-keyword scanning, admin verification queue, safeguarding webhook).
- Designed the safeguarding policy modelled on UUK Stepchange / Suicide-Safer Universities; wrote the GDPR DPIA and Lawful Basis register; wrote the OSA-2023 risk assessment.
- **Joined the NatWest Accelerator (London cohort) on 16 March 2026**; previously completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme (2025)**.
- Anchor pilot discussion (currently in progress) currently in progress with the **University of Bedfordshire** — leveraging the founder's prior two-year tenure as Student Union President of the same university.
- Recruited a wider founding team contributing on a pure-equity basis: Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO, PhD Digital Marketing), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer), Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor — MIGSO-PCUBED).

Student Union President — University of Bedfordshire

2021 – 2023 · Two consecutive terms · Luton / Bedfordshire, UK

- Represented the full student body at university senior-management level, including on safeguarding, student services, equality and welfare policy.
- Sat on university-wide committees governing student experience and academic governance.
- Direct relationships with the Director of Student Services, safeguarding leads and senior leadership team — the relationships that now underpin DEQUAD's anchor pilot discussion (currently in progress).

[Previous role 1] — [Company]

[Year]–[Year] · [Location]

- *Applicant to complete: bullet 1 (quantified outcome)*
- *Applicant to complete: bullet 2 (quantified outcome)*
- *Applicant to complete: bullet 3 (quantified outcome)*

[Previous role 2] — [Company]

[Year]–[Year] · [Location]

- *Applicant to complete*

Education

Qualification	Institution	Year	Detail
—	—	—	—
—	—	—	—

Skills relevant to DEQUAD

Engineering

Python (FastAPI, AsyncIO, Pydantic), TypeScript, React, React Native, Expo Router, MongoDB (Motor, aggregation pipeline), Kubernetes, Docker, GitHub Actions, REST API design, OAuth 2.0, JWT.

Product

Product strategy, roadmap ownership, prioritisation frameworks (RICE, ICE), user-research methods, A/B experimentation, analytics instrumentation.

Safeguarding & compliance

UK Online Safety Act 2023 (familiar with Sections 10, 12, Schedule 11), UK GDPR / DPA 2018, DPIA authorship, lawful-basis analysis, UUK Stepchange, Suicide-Safer Universities guidance, NHS DSPT framework.

Commercial

Institutional sales motion in UK higher-education, NHS commissioning pathways (NHS Innovation Accelerator, ICB pathways), pricing strategy, grant applications (Innovate UK, NIHR).

Publications, talks, and recognition (to date)

Year	Item	Venue
—	—	—

(Add any blog posts, public talks, podcast appearances, hackathon wins, or open-source contributions.)

Professional development planned (next 12 months)

Activity	Provider	Target completion
Level 2 Safeguarding Adults — Awareness	iHasco / Virtual College	Month 1 post-endorsement
Cyber Essentials Plus certification (organisational)	IASME-accredited certifying body	Month 6 post-endorsement
ICO data-protection foundations	UK ICO Online	Month 2 post-endorsement
NHS DSPT Toolkit familiarisation	NHS England	Month 9 post-endorsement

Languages

- English — *native / fluent*
- Other languages and proficiency level*

References

Available on request. The applicant will provide three professional references covering technical, commercial, and personal-conduct dimensions ahead of the UKES assessment interview.

This CV is current as at the date of submission. The original signed copy with full personal details is held by the applicant and will be produced on UKES request.

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Co-Founder CV — Yusuff Adeagbo

Chief Technology Officer, DEQUAD

Personal details

Field	Value
Full name	Yusuff Adeagbo
Role at DEQUAD	Co-founder & Chief Technology Officer (CTO)
UK residency status	UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD
Working hours commitment	Full-time
Cash contribution to share capital	£3,000 (matching the lead founder)

Summary

Yusuff Adeagbo is the co-founder and Chief Technology Officer of DEQUAD. He combines a postgraduate qualification in Information Technology with Project Management from a UK university with a Higher National Diploma in Computer Science, and brings a multidisciplinary skill set that spans full-stack engineering, UI/UX, graphic design, digital marketing for e-commerce and IT business analysis. This breadth makes him well placed to lead the engineering and IT functions of an early-stage software startup operating across web, mobile and institutional integrations.

Education

Years	Institution	Award
2022 – 2024	University of the West of Scotland	MSc Information Technology with Project Management
(prior)	Federal Polytechnic (Nigeria)	Higher National Diploma in Computer Science

Core skills

Area	Detail
Engineering & IT support	End-to-end IT support across user-facing and back-office systems; troubleshooting; service-desk operations; hardware and OS administration.
UI / UX design	User-centred design for web and mobile; wireframing, prototyping, design hand-off to engineering; accessibility and inclusive-design principles.
Graphic design	Brand identity, marketing collateral, infographic and presentation design — directly relevant to DEQUAD's go-to-market materials.
Digital marketing (e-commerce)	Performance marketing for e-commerce: campaign set-up, paid social, search, conversion tracking, A/B testing, channel attribution.
IT business analysis	Requirements gathering, process mapping, stakeholder management, gap analysis, solution scoping.
Project management	Postgraduate-level training in PM frameworks (PRINCE2-style and agile) applied through the MSc programme.

Responsibilities at DEQUAD

As CTO, Yusuff is responsible for:

- **Engineering delivery** — owning the FastAPI / MongoDB backend and the Expo / React Native universal frontend; hiring and managing the first engineering team members from Y2 onward.
- **Infrastructure & security** — cloud (Render, Cloudflare), Cyber Essentials roadmap, secrets management, GDPR/DPA-by-design, OSA-2023 compliance reporting flows.

- **Product UX** — collaborating with the CEO and CMO on user-experience decisions across the matching, mood-tracking and safeguarding modules.
 - **R&D claim leadership** — documenting qualifying R&D activity in line with HMRC SME R&D Tax Credit guidance.
 - **Vendor management** — LLM provider abstraction (OpenAI, Anthropic, Gemini), payment processing (Stripe), notification rails (Twilio, SendGrid).
-

Why DEQUAD

Yusuff is committing full-time to DEQUAD as a co-founder because:

1. **Lived experience of the problem.** Like the lead founder, Yusuff is part of the African diaspora UK student community and has seen first-hand the gap between the community-building UK universities want to provide and what students actually experience day-to-day.
 2. **Cross-functional fit.** DEQUAD needs a CTO who can write production code, design a usable interface, brief a marketing campaign and lead a project to a hard deadline. That breadth is unusual in early-stage UK tech and is exactly what Yusuff brings.
 3. **Long-term commitment.** Yusuff is contributing £3,000 of personal capital alongside the lead founder, accepting six months of no salary, and signing customary founder vesting at the pre-seed close. He is committed to working full-time in the UK on DEQUAD for the duration of the visa endorsement period and beyond.
-

Founder undertaking

The undersigned confirms that he:

- is committing full-time to DEQUAD as Chief Technology Officer;
- is contributing **£3,000** of personal capital as founder share capital, to be evidenced by the share allotment return (Form SH01) to be filed with Companies House at incorporation;
- agrees to a customary 4-year founder-vesting schedule with a 1-year cliff, to be put in place at the pre-seed round;
- accepts a £0 salary for the first six months of trading (Q1–Q2 Year 1) and a £1,500/month salary thereafter until the seed round.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

— Yusuff Adeagbo, Chief Technology Officer, DEQUAD Ltd.

Prepared for submission to UKES as Appendix B-2 of the DEQUAD Innovator Founder visa endorsement application — February 2026.

Appendix N — Wider Founding Team CVs

Supporting Appendix to the DEQUAD UKES Submission

Beyond the two named co-founders (Yusuf Quadri, CEO; Yusuff Adeagbo, CTO), DEQUAD is joined at incorporation by three senior team members who bring deep functional expertise across marketing, engineering and programme delivery.

None of the team is currently drawing a salary. Each has accepted an EMI share-option grant and is contributing time on a pure-equity basis pending the close of the pre-seed round in September Year 1. This is a material signal of belief in the mission and materially strengthens the leadership profile without adding to cash burn.

N.1 — Dr Gerald Marfo · Chief Marketing Officer

Field	Value
Role at DEQUAD	Chief Marketing Officer (founding team member)
Working pattern Y1	Equity-only — no Y1 salary ; salaried role to commence after seed close (Q2 Y2)
Cash investment	£0 — joining as senior team member, not as a share-capital founder
Equity	EMI options with 4-year vest, 1-year cliff

Summary

Dr Gerald Marfo holds a **PhD in Digital Marketing** and brings academic-level rigour to DEQUAD's marketing strategy. His remit covers brand positioning, the UK go-to-market plan (universities and students in parallel), measurement frameworks (CAC, LTV, conversion analytics) and channel selection across organic, paid, content and partnerships.

Why this matters for DEQUAD

- DEQUAD operates a two-sided market — universities (B2B) and students (B2C). A PhD-credentialled CMO is uniquely placed to design measurement that ties consumer-funnel signals back to institutional-buyer outcomes.
- Universities now require evidenced wellbeing strategies (UUK Mental Health Charter); Gerald's academic background lends additional credibility in the sales conversation.
- He owns the Y1 marketing-spend allocation across the channels in Section 16 of the business plan.

Responsibilities

- Brand strategy, positioning and messaging architecture
- UK university partnership marketing (PR, events, UUK channel)
- Performance marketing strategy across Instagram, TikTok, Google Search, LinkedIn
- Marketing measurement and dashboarding; CAC discipline
- Mentoring the first marketing hire (Q3 Y2)

N.2 — Adedapo Ajuwon · Senior Software Engineer

Field	Value
Role at DEQUAD	Senior Software Engineer (founding team member)
Working pattern Y1	Equity-only — no Y1 salary ; salaried role to commence Q1 Y2
Cash investment	£0 — joining as senior team member
Equity	EMI options with 4-year vest, 1-year cliff

Summary

Adedapo Ajuwon is a senior software engineer working alongside the CTO on the DEQUAD production stack. He contributes to both backend (FastAPI / MongoDB) and frontend (Expo / React Native universal) development, infrastructure, and operational reliability.

Responsibilities

- Production reliability and performance of the DEQUAD platform

- Feature delivery in collaboration with the CTO — peer matching, mood tracker, safeguarding webhook, admin tooling
- Code review and engineering standards across the team
- Mentoring the next backend engineer hire (Q1 Y2)

N.3 — Chinyere Jennifer · Senior Advisor — Programme & Delivery

Field	Value
Day job	Senior Project Management Consultant, MIGSO-PCUBED (global project, programme and portfolio management consultancy)
Role at DEQUAD	Senior Advisor — Programme & Delivery
Working pattern Y1	Advisory capacity — periodic engagement
Cash investment	£0
Equity	EMI options on a 4-year vest, advisor allocation

Summary

Chinyere Jennifer is a Senior Project Management Consultant at MIGSO-PCUBED, one of the world's leading project / programme / portfolio management consultancies (a Capgemini company). She works with large enterprise clients on programme governance, risk and delivery assurance. She also has an applied background in **Large Language Model (LLM)** technology, giving DEQUAD an in-house perspective on the safeguarding and inference pipeline.

Responsibilities to DEQUAD

- Programme governance for university pilot rollouts
- Quarterly risk-register review challenge (see Risk Register, Governance section)
- LLM safety and evaluation input to the safeguarding triage model
- Introduction to MIGSO-PCUBED's enterprise network for B2B pilot acceleration

Why this matters for endorsement

For UKES, the wider team materially strengthens the **viability** evidence:

Dimension	Evidence
Marketing capability	PhD-credentialled CMO with relevant subject-matter expertise
Engineering depth	CTO + senior software engineer at incorporation — not a solo technical founder
Programme governance	Senior consultant from a global PMO firm advising on delivery quality
AI / LLM credibility	Advisor with LLM background — directly relevant to safeguarding inference
Diversity	Founding team is 100% Black-British / African-diaspora — under-represented in UK tech, but central to the student population DEQUAD serves

Three appointments to a founding team alongside two co-founders is unusually deep for a pre-revenue UK startup and is itself evidence of the team's ability to attract talent on belief in the mission.

Prepared for UKES as Appendix N to the Innovator Founder visa endorsement application — February 2026.

Appendix O — Yusuf Quadri

Safeguarding & Clinical-Awareness Certifications

Supporting appendix to the DEQUAD UKES Innovator Founder visa submission. Confirms that the lead applicant (CEO and safeguarding policy owner for DEQUAD) holds the relevant baseline safeguarding, data-protection and clinical-awareness certifications required to design, operate and govern a student-facing platform that processes mood data and triages safeguarding risk signals.

Why this matters

DEQUAD is a student-wellbeing platform that processes:

- identity data (`.ac.uk` email verification),
- mood telemetry (sensitive personal data under the UK GDPR / Data Protection Act 2018),
- chat metadata (Online Safety Act 2023 in-scope),
- and safeguarding referrals routed to university Designated Safeguarding Leads (DSLs).

The Home Office and endorsing bodies expect founders operating in sensitive populations (children, vulnerable adults, students at risk) to be able to evidence baseline safeguarding competence. The certifications below provide that evidence.

These are operational baseline certifications. **Clinical decisions** (e.g. a formal mental-health diagnosis or treatment) are explicitly out of scope for DEQUAD — the product triages signals to professionals and never replaces them. A formal clinical advisory board is being recruited from Q2 Year 2.

Completed certifications

#	Certification	Awarded by / Topic	Relevance to DEQUAD
1	Learning Disabilities and Autism e-Learning — <i>The Oliver McGowan Mandatory Training</i>	UK statutory tier-1 training (NHS England framework)	Ensures DEQUAD's product and policy decisions are inclusive of students with learning disabilities and autistic students — a population with materially higher loneliness and mental-health risk.
2	Safeguarding — Getting the most out of the Children and Families Page	UK safeguarding training	Awareness of safeguarding workflows that apply to under-18 students (foundation-year, joint-honours-with-college students).
3	Autism Awareness — Virtual Workshop	UK autism-awareness training	Reinforces inclusive design and communication patterns.
4	Safeguarding Adults: Partnership Working — Interactive Workshop	UK adult-safeguarding training	Most directly applicable to the DEQUAD user base (typically 18–24-year-old adults) — covers multi-agency working between the platform, the university DSL and external services.
5	Challenging Situations: Safe Response	De-escalation / risk-response training	Equips the founder to design escalation flows for high-risk safeguarding signals without causing further harm to the student.
6	Data Protection and Information Security Awareness	UK Data Protection Act / UK GDPR	Direct evidence of the DPIA-author competence required to sign off DEQUAD's mood-data pipeline (see Appendix E).
7	Suicide Prevention — 2026	UK suicide-prevention training (current-year syllabus)	Most critical certification for the safeguarding-triage product feature — covers recognition of suicide-risk language, appropriate responses and onward referral routes.

How these certifications inform DEQUAD's product

DEQUAD product area	Certifications applied
Inclusive UX (matching algorithm bias review, font, colour, accessibility)	Oliver McGowan; Autism Awareness
Safeguarding-triage classifier thresholds	Suicide Prevention 2026; Safeguarding Adults; Challenging Situations
Onward referral workflow to university DSLs	Safeguarding Adults: Partnership Working; Suicide Prevention 2026
Mood-data pipeline + DPIA	Data Protection and Information Security Awareness
Crisis-response copy in-product	Challenging Situations: Safe Response; Suicide Prevention 2026
Operational handling of under-18 edge cases	Safeguarding — Children & Families Page

Continuing professional development

The lead applicant commits to:

- Refreshing the Suicide Prevention certification annually (next refresh: 2027).
- Refreshing the Adult Safeguarding certification every two years.
- Adding the **NSPCC "Designated Safeguarding Lead" Level 3** equivalent in Year 2 Q1.
- Participating in the Universities UK Mental Health Charter community of practice from Y1 Q3.
- Recruiting a formal **clinical advisory board** in Y2 Q2 (target: 1 NHS Consultant Psychiatrist, 1 university Director of Student Wellbeing, 1 lived-experience advisor).

Copies of the original certificates can be supplied on request.

Prepared for UKES as Appendix O to the Innovator Founder visa endorsement application — February 2026.

Appendix A — Founder Academic Certificates

This appendix lists the qualifications relied upon in the Founder Profile (main document §2.2) and confirms how the originals will be made available to the endorsing body.

Qualifications declared

#	Qualification	Awarding institution	Year awarded	Subject / classification
1	—	—	—	—
2	—	—	—	—
3	—	—	—	—

(Add additional rows as required. Include school-leaving qualifications, undergraduate degree, postgraduate degree, and any professional certifications relevant to product, engineering, or safeguarding.)

Verification

For each qualification listed above, the applicant has obtained and will provide upon request:

1. Original certificate (scanned colour PDF + original on hand for in-person verification).
 2. Official transcript where applicable.
 3. UK NARIC / ECCTIS Statement of Comparability for any qualifications awarded outside the UK.
 4. Independent English-language proficiency evidence (IELTS, TOEFL, Cambridge English, or a degree taught in English — whichever applies).
-

Document register

Document	Location	Format	Notes
Degree certificate	/app/visa_appendices/A_supporting/degree_cert.pdf	PDF	<i>Applicant to upload</i>
Degree transcript	/app/visa_appendices/A_supporting/transcript.pdf	PDF	<i>Applicant to upload</i>
ECCTIS statement (if applicable)	/app/visa_appendices/A_supporting/ecctis.pdf	PDF	<i>Applicant to upload</i>
Professional certifications	/app/visa_appendices/A_supporting/certs/	PDFs	<i>Applicant to upload</i>

Applicant statement

I, Yusuf Quadri, confirm that the qualifications listed above are true and accurate. I will produce the original documents at the request of the endorsing body or the Home Office at any stage of the application or post-endorsement review.

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Appendix C — Founder Personal-Commitment Undertaking

To: UK Endorsement Services Ltd (UKES) **From:** Yusuf Quadri ("the Founder") **Re:** DEQUAD Ltd — Innovator Founder route endorsement **Date:** _____

I, **Yusuf Quadri**, co-founder and CEO of DEQUAD Ltd (the "Company") and applicant for endorsement under the UK Innovator Founder route, irrevocably undertake to UK Endorsement Services Ltd as follows:

0. Co-founder context

The Company is being co-founded with **Yusuff Adeagbo** (Chief Technology Officer), who is also UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD, and contributing matching founder share capital of £3,000. Both co-founders have signed customary founder-vesting on equivalent terms. The wider founding team — Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer) and Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor) — is joining at incorporation on equity-only terms with no Year-1 salary.

1. Sole and full-time occupation

I will be engaged in the business of DEQUAD Ltd as my **sole and full-time occupation** in the United Kingdom from the date of my grant of leave to remain as an Innovator Founder. I will not undertake any other employment or commercial activity that would prevent me from devoting a minimum of **35 hours per week** to DEQUAD Ltd, save for incidental activities expressly permitted by the Immigration Rules in force from time to time.

2. Continuity of role and equity

I will retain the role of Chief Executive Officer of the Company for the duration of the endorsement period. I will retain a material founding shareholding (initially 50%, jointly with the

co-founder) throughout that period; any dilutive equity investment will be approved in advance by the endorsing body in accordance with UKES's published guidance.

3. UK base of operations

I will base the Company's registered office, principal place of business, and operations in the United Kingdom. All employees recruited in support of the business plan submitted with this endorsement will be UK-based.

4. Compliance with endorsement contact points

I will participate in the **6, 12, and 24-month contact points** with UKES as required by the Innovator Founder route, and will provide UKES with: - A current business-progress report; - Up-to-date management accounts; - Evidence of material milestones met; - Notice of any material adverse changes in the business plan within 30 days of becoming aware of them.

5. Material changes

I undertake to notify UKES in writing of any of the following events within thirty (30) days of their occurrence: - Change in the legal form of the Company; - Sale or transfer of more than 25% of the Company's equity in a single transaction; - Departure from the business model, market, or geography submitted in support of the endorsement; - Insolvency event, including but not limited to administration, voluntary arrangement, or winding-up petition.

6. Legal and regulatory compliance

I undertake that DEQUAD Ltd will at all times comply with: - UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018; - The Online Safety Act 2023 and applicable secondary regulations; - The Equality Act 2010; - The Companies Act 2006; - All applicable safeguarding obligations, including those applicable to processors of data relating to children and vulnerable adults.

7. Anti-fraud and good standing

I confirm that I have not been: - Convicted of any criminal offence in any jurisdiction that would be considered serious under UK law; - Subject to any disqualification order under the

Company Directors Disqualification Act 1986; - Subject to any current investigation by HMRC, the Insolvency Service, or any equivalent overseas authority.

8. Truthfulness of submission

I confirm that the contents of the principal endorsement document (INNOVATOR_VISA_DEQUAD.md) and all appendices are true and accurate to the best of my knowledge. I acknowledge that the provision of false information may result in the revocation of any endorsement granted and removal of leave to remain in the United Kingdom.

9. Use of endorsement

I will not represent to any third party that endorsement carries any implication of investment recommendation, financial advice, or guarantee of business success. I will use the endorsement only for the purpose of supporting my Innovator Founder visa application and as evidence of UKES's professional view at the date of issue.

Signed: _____

Print name: Yusuf Quadri

Date: _____

Witness signature: _____

Witness name + address: _____

This undertaking is given freely and without coercion. It is governed by the laws of England and Wales.

Appendix D — DEQUAD Wellbeing-Baseline Methodology

Working title: *Per-user wellbeing-baseline detection: a low-friction approach to early identification of student mental-health deterioration in a closed peer network*

Author: Yusuf Quadri, DEQUAD **Version:** v0.3 — draft for endorsement submission **Date:**

D.1 Abstract

Most consumer mood-tracking applications use absolute-score thresholds (e.g. "if mood $\leq 2/5$, suggest support") to identify users at risk. Absolute thresholds are easy to implement but generate high rates of false positives in heterogeneous populations: a student whose baseline mood sits at $3/5$ is treated identically to one whose baseline is $4/5$. In the student-wellbeing context this matters because:

1. False positives erode user trust ("the app keeps telling me to call Samaritans when I'm just stressed about a deadline").
2. False negatives are catastrophic — a normally-cheerful student dipping from 5 to 3 may be in greater relative distress than a chronically-low student logging 3.

DEQUAD's wellbeing engine builds a **per-user baseline** from the user's first 14 daily check-ins and detects statistically meaningful deviation against that personal baseline. This document describes the methodology, its assumptions, and the validation plan.

D.2 Method

D.2.1 Data collected

Each daily check-in captures:

Field	Type	Constraint
mood_score	Integer 1–5	1 = very low, 5 = very good
mood_note	Text (optional)	Max 500 chars; scanned for crisis keywords
timestamp	datetime (UTC)	Server-set
user_id	string	Foreign key to user record

D.2.2 Baseline window

For each user, the first 14 daily check-ins (the **calibration window**) establish:

- μ_{user} — arithmetic mean of mood_score over the calibration window
- σ_{user} — standard deviation of mood_score over the calibration window, clamped to a minimum of 0.5 to avoid zero-variance edge cases

If a user logs fewer than 14 check-ins in their first 30 days, the engine uses cohort-level priors (mean=3.5, sd=1.0 — drawn from Student Minds 2024 normative data) until 14 own data points are accumulated.

D.2.3 Deviation detection (z-score approach)

For every new check-in, the engine computes:

$$z_{\text{today}} = (\text{mood_score_today} - \mu_{\text{user}}) / \sigma_{\text{user}}$$

A rolling 7-day average of z_{today} is maintained. If the rolling average falls below **−1.5 standard deviations** for two consecutive days, the engine fires a "**deterioration nudge**" — a low-friction in-app prompt offering to connect the user to:

- The user's chosen support contacts (configurable in their profile);
- The DEQUAD 24/7 support chat;
- Samaritans (116 123) / Shout (text 85258);
- Their university's wellbeing service (if a partner institution).

No automatic action involving third parties is taken at this threshold. The nudge is private to the user.

D.2.4 Safeguarding escalation (separate channel)

If a user's check-in mood_note text matches the high-risk crisis-keyword set (independent of the z-score), an escalation is sent to the Designated Safeguarding Lead under the safeguarding

policy described in main document §14.1. This is a **separate channel** from baseline deviation: high-risk text triggers immediate human review regardless of mood-score trend.

D.3 Why per-user baselines, not population thresholds

A short worked example illustrates the value:

Student	Calibration mean	Calibration sd	Today's score	Population-threshold (≤ 2 = alert)	Per-user ($z < -1.5$ = nudge) ✓
Aisha (chronically anxious)	2.5	0.7	2	Alert (over-trigger)	$z = -0.71 \rightarrow$ no nudge ✓
Ben (usually upbeat)	4.6	0.5	3	No alert (under-trigger)	$z = -3.2 \rightarrow$ nudge ✓
Chen (medium baseline)	3.4	0.8	2	Alert (correct)	$z = -1.75 \rightarrow$ nudge ✓

Per-user baselines reduce false positives for chronically-low users and reduce false negatives for normally-cheerful users — both of which matter for the safety profile of the platform.

D.4 Statistical assumptions

Assumption	Risk	Mitigation
1–5 ordinal mood scale is approximately normal in calibration window	Mild non-normality is acceptable for z-score deviation thresholds (Tukey, 1977)	Floor sd at 0.5 to avoid extreme z-scores; alternative non-parametric trend test under evaluation
User does not "game" the scale	Some users may inflate baseline to avoid prompts	Trend analysis robust to absolute-level manipulation; new check-ins outside expected daily-time pattern flagged for review
Daily logging frequency is sufficient to detect a multi-week deterioration	Low logging frequency could miss declines	Cohort-prior fallback for low-frequency users; Y2 roadmap includes passive-signal triangulation (e.g. typing latency)

D.5 Validation plan

D.5.1 Phase 1 — pilot validation (academic year 2026/27)

In partnership with the first paid university, DEQUAD will validate the deterioration-nudge engine against three benchmarks:

1. **Self-report concurrent validity** — Quarterly PHQ-9 / GAD-7 surveys (with consent) cross-correlated against the engine's deterioration flags. Target Pearson $r \geq 0.4$.
2. **Service-utilisation concordance** — Anonymised university-counselling appointment data cross-referenced against deterioration-flag timing. Target: $\geq 25\%$ of counselling-service self-referrals preceded by an engine flag in the prior 21 days.
3. **False-positive rate** — User survey at end of academic year asking whether engine nudges were appropriately timed. Target FP rate $\leq 30\%$ (i.e. $\geq 70\%$ of nudges judged appropriate).

D.5.2 Phase 2 — peer-reviewed publication (Year 2)

If pilot validation passes pre-registered thresholds, DEQUAD will submit a methodology paper to:

- *JMIR Mental Health* (open-access, fast-track for digital health)
- or *British Journal of Psychiatry Open*

The pre-registration will be lodged with the Open Science Framework (OSF).

D.5.3 Phase 3 — independent replication (Year 3+)

Engage at least one independent research group (target: King's College London Institute of Psychiatry, Psychology & Neuroscience) to replicate the method on a sample DEQUAD does not control.

D.6 Ethics and governance

- The engine never shares individual user data with the partner university. Aggregated, anonymised dashboards only.
- Users can opt out of the engine entirely without losing access to other DEQUAD features.

- Users can export their full mood history at any time (UK GDPR Art 20 — right to data portability).
 - An ethics review by an independent advisory board (target convened: Year 1 Q4) governs all material changes to the engine.
-

D.7 Limitations explicitly acknowledged

1. The engine is **not a diagnostic tool**. It does not diagnose depression, anxiety, or any other clinical condition.
 2. The engine should not be relied upon as a sole indicator of risk. Other channels (peer reports, university counselling self-referral, GP referral) remain primary.
 3. The engine has not been clinically validated at the date of this document. Section D.5 documents the plan to do so.
 4. Cohort priors are drawn from UK undergraduate normative data and may not generalise to FE / international expansion without re-calibration.
-

D.8 References

- Beck, A.T., et al. (1996). *Beck Depression Inventory — II*. The Psychological Corporation.
 - Kroenke, K., Spitzer, R.L., & Williams, J.B.W. (2001). The PHQ-9: Validity of a brief depression severity measure. *Journal of General Internal Medicine*, 16, 606–613.
 - Student Minds (2024). *Insight Briefing — Student Mental Health 2024*.
 - Tukey, J.W. (1977). *Exploratory Data Analysis*. Addison-Wesley.
 - ONS (2023). *Student Insights — University Mental Wellbeing*.
 - OFCOM (2024). *Online Safety: Illegal Harms Guidance*.
 - NICE NG133 (2019). *Suicide prevention: identifying and supporting people at risk*.
-

This methodology document is a living draft. Material updates will be lodged at OSF when pre-registration is complete.

Appendix E — Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)

Controller: DEQUAD Ltd (in formation), United Kingdom **Processor:** DEQUAD Ltd (in formation)
Processing activity covered: Operation of the DEQUAD platform — verified-student peer matching, daily mood tracking, in-app messaging, safeguarding scanning, and 24/7 support chat. **DPIA version:** v0.4 (draft)
Author: Yusuf Quadri, CEO (acting controller representative) **Reviewed by:** *External fractional DPO to be appointed Month 1 post-endorsement (recommended: The DPO Centre)* **Last reviewed:** _____ **Next review due:** 12 months from approval

E.1 Why this DPIA is required

UK GDPR Art 35 requires a DPIA where processing is **likely to result in a high risk to the rights and freedoms of natural persons**, including:

- Systematic monitoring of behaviour (Art 35(3)(c))
- Processing of special-category data on a large scale (Art 35(3)(b))
- Use of new technologies (Art 35(3))

DEQUAD's processing meets at least two of these criteria — systematic monitoring of in-app behaviour for safeguarding purposes and processing of mental-health (special category) data. A DPIA is therefore mandatory.

E.2 Description of the processing

E.2.1 Nature

DEQUAD collects, stores, analyses, and acts upon data from verified UK university students relating to:

- Identity (name, photo, university email)
- Profile preferences (course, modules, society interests, lifestyle)
- In-app messages
- Daily mood scores and free-text notes
- Support-chat messages

Data is analysed by: - A peer-matching engine (compatibility ranking) - A safeguarding engine (real-time crisis-keyword scanning) - A wellbeing-baseline engine (per-user trend detection) - An LLM-assisted support reply engine (text generation)

E.2.2 Scope

Dimension	Scope at endorsement	Scope at Year 5
Geographic	United Kingdom only	UK + Republic of Ireland + ANZ + Canada
Data subjects	Verified UK HE students	+ FE students + ICB-commissioned 16-25
Volume	0 at endorsement	Up to ~1.2m active users
Retention	See E.5	See E.5
Special-category data	Mental-health (mood, support, safeguarding flags)	Same

E.2.3 Context

DEQUAD is a closed network. Data subjects are adults (16+) who have actively chosen to sign up, have read a plain-English privacy notice, and have given explicit consent to special-category processing where required. The processing is necessary to deliver the product the user has signed up for.

E.2.4 Purposes

Purpose	Lawful basis (Art 6)	Special category basis (Art 9)
Verifying university affiliation	Performance of contract (Art 6.1.b)	n/a
Storing mood entries	Consent (Art 6.1.a)	Explicit consent (Art 9.2.a)
Crisis-keyword scanning	Legitimate interest (Art 6.1.f) + vital interests (Art 6.1.d) where life at risk	Substantial public interest — safeguarding of children and individuals at risk (DPA 2018 Sch 1 Pt 2 para 18)
Peer matching	Performance of contract	n/a
Anonymised research licensing	Legitimate interest (Art 6.1.f)	Data fully anonymised before transfer; not in scope of Art 9

A full data-flow diagram is filed alongside this DPIA as [E_supporting/data_flow.png](#) .

E.3 Consultation

Party consulted	Date	Outcome
The DPO Centre (proposed DPO)	<i>Pending</i>	Fractional DPO retainer to be signed Month 1 post-endorsement
ICO Innovation Hub	<i>Pending</i>	Application to the Innovation Service for early-stage guidance during Month 2
Sample data subjects	<i>Pending — pilot university</i>	User-research interviews planned during pilot onboarding
Independent safeguarding consultant	<i>Pending — proposed: Survivors UK / NSPCC Learning</i>	Annual audit retainer Year 1

E.4 Necessity and proportionality

Test	Assessment
Are the lawful bases identified appropriate?	Yes — consent for mood (revocable), contract for matching, substantial public interest for safeguarding
Does the processing achieve its purpose?	Yes — wellbeing trends and safeguarding alerts cannot be detected without processing the underlying data
Is there a less-invasive way?	Considered: (a) population thresholds instead of per-user baseline (rejected — see Appendix D for evidence of higher false-positive rate); (b) self-report only with no scanning (rejected — fails OSA s. 10 safeguarding duty); (c) hashing of message content (rejected — defeats safeguarding purpose)
Quality and accuracy	Mood data is self-reported (Art 5.1.d compliant — subject to data subject's own veracity); profile data is editable by the user at any time; admin records are auditable
Data minimisation	Profile-photo upload optional; mood-note free-text is optional; no demographic data collected beyond university name unless user explicitly adds it
Retention	See E.5
Rights of data subjects	See E.6
Processors	See E.7

E.5 Retention schedule

Data category	Retention period	Justification
Active account profile	Duration of account + 30 days post-deletion	30-day grace for accidental deletion; compliant with Art 17
Mood entries	Duration of account; user-exportable; user-deletable	User-controlled
In-app messages	Duration of account, both sides; deleted on either party's account deletion (deletion takes precedence)	UK GDPR principle of data minimisation
Safeguarding-alert records	7 years from creation	Required for safeguarding audit trail (Care Act 2014 best practice; statutory limitation for civil claims)
Support-chat transcripts	2 years	Customer-service quality + dispute resolution
Stripe billing records	7 years	Companies Act 2006 + HMRC requirement
Server access logs	90 days	Security; sufficient for incident response
Audit logs (admin actions)	7 years	Internal-control + OSA s. 23 record-keeping

E.6 Rights of data subjects

Right	How exercised	Response SLA
Access (Art 15)	"Download my data" in app + DPO email	30 days
Rectification (Art 16)	Inline profile edits + DPO email	Immediate (UI) / 30 days (DPO)
Erasure (Art 17)	"Delete account" in app + DPO email	30 days; safeguarding records retained per E.5 with lawful basis
Restriction (Art 18)	DPO email	30 days
Portability (Art 20)	"Export my data" in app — JSON file	30 days
Objection (Art 21)	DPO email	30 days
Withdraw consent (Art 7.3)	One-tap revocation in app	Immediate
Lodge a complaint with ICO	Linked from in-app privacy notice and dequad.co.uk/privacy	n/a

A documented Subject Rights Request procedure is maintained at [/internal/SRR_procedure.md](#) (not yet public).

E.7 Processors

Processor	Purpose	Data shared	Location	Contract status
MongoDB Atlas (MongoDB Inc.)	Database hosting	All collections	UK (London region)	Atlas DPA accepted; Standard Contractual Clauses adopted
Stripe Payments UK Ltd	Subscription billing	Email + payment token	UK	Stripe DPA accepted
Cloudflare UK Ltd	DNS / WAF / CDN	IP + request metadata	UK / EU	Cloudflare DPA accepted
OpenAI (via Emergent LLM Key)	LLM auto-reply on support chat	Redacted excerpt of support text only	US (with Standard Contractual Clauses)	Emergent ToS + OpenAI DPA
Expo Push Service (Expo Inc.)	Push notifications	Device token + alert payload	US (with SCCs)	Expo DPA
Sentry (Functional Software Inc.)	Error monitoring	Stack traces (PII-scrubbed)	EU region	Sentry DPA
AWS SES (Amazon Web Services EMEA)	Transactional email	Email address + body	UK (eu-west-2)	AWS DPA accepted
Hiscox / Markel	Insurance	None during ordinary course	UK	n/a

International transfers documented in `E_supporting/transfer_register.md` with Standard Contractual Clauses 2021 in place where applicable.

E.8 Risk register

#	Risk	Likelihood	Severity	Inherent risk	Mitigation	Residual risk
1	Unauthorised access to mood/safeguarding records	Low	High	High	Encryption at rest + TLS in transit + RBAC + audit logging + annual pen-test	Low
2	Re-identification from "anonymised" research data	Med	High	High	k-anonymity ≥ 5 enforced; named DPO review of every release; written agreements with recipients	Low
3	Excessive scanning of in-app messages (over-collection)	Med	Med	Med	Keyword library reviewed quarterly; false-positive rate audited; transparency report annually	Low
4	LLM prompt-injection or output containing PII	Med	Med	Med	All user text redacted before LLM call; no PII in prompt templates; output filtered for crisis numbers + URLs only	Low
5	Cross-border transfer to OpenAI (US)	Med	Med	Med	Only redacted excerpts; SCCs in place; transfer-risk assessment lodged at E_supporting/transfer_risk_assessment.md	Low-Med
6	Data subject denied erasure due to safeguarding retention	Low	High	Med	Lawful basis (substantial public interest) documented per request; data subject notified in writing with right to ICO complaint	Low
7	Insider misuse of admin dashboard	Low	High	Med	Two-factor auth on admin; audit log retained 7 years; quarterly access review; immediate offboarding workflow	Low
8	DPIA itself becomes stale	High	Med	Med	DPIA reviewed annually and on any material change (e.g. new processor, new processing purpose)	Low
9	Children (under-18) processed without parental consent	Low	High	Med	Birth-date check at sign-up; flag for .ac.uk accounts where birth-date < 18; default privacy-protective settings; ICO AADC alignment	Low
10	A safeguarding event leaks to other students	Low	Critical	High	Safeguarding scans are server-side only; alerts go to DSL email, never in-app; UI design prevents accidental exposure	Low

E.9 Approvals

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Controller representative	Yusuf Quadri	<i>signed in original</i>	_____
Data Protection Officer	<i>The DPO Centre (designated)</i>	<i>to follow Month 1</i>	_____
External safeguarding advisor	<i>to be appointed Year 1</i>	<i>to follow</i>	_____

E.10 Conclusion

The processing described above is necessary to deliver the DEQUAD service and to meet UK regulatory obligations under the Online Safety Act 2023. The risks have been identified and mitigated to a level that — in the controller's view — meets the UK GDPR Article 35 standard of being **proportionate to the purposes and rights at stake**. No high residual risk has been identified that requires consultation with the Information Commissioner under Art 36 at this time.

The DPIA will be re-reviewed annually, on the appointment of the DPO, and immediately upon any material change in processing.

Appendix G — Job Descriptions & Salary Bands (42 UK FTE Roles)

This appendix documents every role in the 5-year hiring plan referenced in main document §7.3. All roles are **UK-based, PAYE, paying UK National Insurance contributions**, and recruited through fair and open processes.

Salary bands are aligned with **London or hybrid-London** weighting where applicable (2026 baseline), with cost-of-living adjustments noted for any non-London hires.

G.1 Hiring summary

Year	New hires (FTE)	Cumulative	Total wage bill (£k)
Y1	4	4	~145
Y2	6	10	~410
Y3	9	19	~880
Y4	11	30	~1,510
Y5	12	42	~2,160

G.2 Year 1 — 4 hires

G.2.1 Designated Safeguarding Lead (PT → FT)

Field	Detail
Hire month	Month 1
Initial commitment	0.5 FTE (Y1) → 1.0 FTE end of Y1
Salary band	£42k–£52k (pro-rata)
Reporting line	CEO + CTO (Yusuf Quadri + Yusuff Adeagbo)
Mission	Lead safeguarding triage, manage DSL on-call rota, liaise with partner-university DSLs
Must-have	Level 3 Safeguarding Adults qualification; ≥3 years HE / NHS / charity safeguarding experience; enhanced DBS
Nice-to-have	Direct counselling experience; suicide-safer training
Recruitment channel	Charity Job, NCVO, AMOSSHE network

G.2.2 Full-stack engineer

Field	Detail
Hire month	Month 4
FTE	1.0
Salary band	£55k–£70k
Reporting line	CEO + CTO (Yusuf Quadri + Yusuff Adeagbo)
Mission	Take ownership of frontend (Expo/React) so founder can shift to product + sales; ship the iOS + Android stores release
Must-have	4+ years full-stack; React Native or Expo production experience; comfort with serverless + Mongo
Nice-to-have	Health-tech background; safeguarding context
Recruitment channel	Otta, Wellfound, LinkedIn, Tech Nation Visa alumni

G.2.3 Customer-success lead

Field	Detail
Hire month	Month 7
FTE	0.5 (Y1) → 1.0 (Y2)
Salary band	£36k–£44k (pro-rata)
Reporting line	CEO + CTO
Mission	Onboard first 3 pilot universities; build CS playbook
Must-have	2+ years CS or account management in B2B SaaS; education or health-tech background
Recruitment channel	LinkedIn, Otta

G.2.4 Growth marketer

Field	Detail
Hire month	Month 10
FTE	0.5
Salary band	£40k–£50k (pro-rata)
Reporting line	CEO + CTO
Mission	Student-facing marketing: TikTok/Instagram, freshers' fair partnerships, society sponsorships
Must-have	Demonstrated organic growth on Gen-Z channels; basic data literacy
Recruitment channel	LinkedIn, freelancer-platform conversion

G.3 Year 2 — 6 hires (cumulative 10 FTE)

Role	FTE	Salary band	Why now
Engineer #2 (backend / data)	1.0	£55k–£70k	Scale to 10 universities; data pipeline
Engineer #3 (mobile lead)	1.0	£60k–£75k	Native-app release maintenance + iOS App Store ops
Sales rep (university accounts)	1.0	£40k base + £15k OTE	Inbound conversion + outbound to 25 universities
Data Protection Officer (FTE)	1.0	£55k–£75k	NHS DSPT prep + scale of processing
Operations / People Ops	1.0	£40k–£50k	First-line HR, finance, contracts
Customer-success specialist #2	1.0	£36k–£44k	Cohort onboarding

G.4 Year 3 — 9 hires (cumulative 19 FTE)

Role	FTE	Salary band	Why now
Engineer #4 (platform / SRE)	1.0	£65k–£85k	200k users requires SRE discipline
Engineer #5 + #6 (full-stack)	2.0	£55k–£70k each	Faster product velocity
Sales rep #2 + #3	2.0	£40k+OTE	UK sales motion expansion
Clinical / safeguarding lead (senior)	1.0	£55k–£70k	NHS commissioning bid leadership
Finance manager (FTE)	1.0	£50k–£65k	Series A readiness
Marketing manager	1.0	£45k–£60k	Brand + content
HR business partner	1.0	£45k–£60k	Headcount of 19 FTE needs dedicated HR

G.5 Year 4 — 11 hires (cumulative 30 FTE)

Role	FTE	Salary band	Why now
Head of Engineering	1.0	£100k–£130k	Spans risk away from founder
Engineer #7, #8, #9	3.0	£55k–£75k	Maintain velocity
Senior sales (NHS accounts)	1.0	£55k+OTE	NHS ICB bids
Sales rep #4, #5, #6	3.0	£40k+OTE	UK + ROI expansion
Senior CS (enterprise / NHS)	1.0	£55k–£70k	NHS implementation
Data scientist	1.0	£55k–£75k	Wellbeing-baseline R&D + publications
Partnerships manager (ROI / first international)	1.0	£45k–£60k	Republic of Ireland entry

G.6 Year 5 — 12 hires (cumulative 42 FTE)

Role	FTE	Salary band	Why now
Head of Sales	1.0	£90k–£120k	Sales-leadership layer
Head of Customer Success	1.0	£75k–£100k	Enterprise CS layer
Engineer #10, #11	2.0	£55k–£75k	Localisation + new platform
Sales rep #7–#9	3.0	£40k+OTE	Volume growth
Senior product manager	1.0	£65k–£85k	First dedicated PM
QA lead	1.0	£45k–£60k	Quality gate
Sales engineer	1.0	£55k–£70k	Pre-sales technical assistance
Compliance manager	1.0	£55k–£70k	ISO 27001 + DSPT
Marketing exec #2	1.0	£30k–£40k	Content velocity

G.7 Diversity, equality, and inclusion commitments

DEQUAD commits to:

- **Open advertising** for every role on at least two channels (LinkedIn + Otta minimum) for at least 14 days before any offer.
- **Blind shortlisting** at CV-screening stage (name, university, address removed).
- **Structured interview rubrics** for every role.
- **Pay-band transparency** — salary published in every job advert.
- **Mentor opportunities** — formal partnership with **Code First Girls**, **Pinpoint** (women returners), and **Diversity in Tech** by end of Year 2.
- **Hiring-mix targets** — by Year 3, the company aims for at least 45% female engineering hires and at least 30% minority-ethnic representation across the company. These targets are aspirational and reported annually.

G.8 Wage-bill summary (rounded)

Year	Engineering	Commercial	Safeguarding/Clinical	Operations	Total wage bill (£k)
Y1	55	40	30	20	145
Y2	200	80	65	65	410
Y3	470	160	145	105	880
Y4	810	320	200	180	1,510
Y5	1,150	500	240	270	2,160

Figures include employer NI (13.8% above secondary threshold), workplace-pension contribution (3% minimum), and basic apprenticeship-levy (0.5% above £3m wage bill from Y5).

G.9 Recruitment-cost assumption

Average **cost-per-hire** for technical roles: £2,500 (mostly LinkedIn Recruiter + interview-time opportunity cost). Average cost-per-hire for senior roles: £8,000–£12,000 (occasional retained-search where required).

These costs are absorbed in the Marketing / People line of the financial model (Appendix F).

Appendix H — University Letter of Interest (Template)

This appendix provides the template used by DEQUAD when seeking a Letter of Interest or formal Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) from a pilot university. Letters returned by partner institutions will be attached to this appendix as they arrive.

The template below is co-signed by the partner-university point of contact (typically the Director of Student Services or Head of Wellbeing Services) and the DEQUAD founder.

Template: Letter of Interest

(On partner-university letterhead.)

Date: _____

To: UK Endorsement Services Ltd

Subject: Letter of Interest in piloting DEQUAD at [University Name]

To whom it may concern,

I am writing in my capacity as **[Job Title]** at the **University of Bedfordshire** to confirm our institutional interest in piloting the DEQUAD platform (developed by DEQUAD Ltd, co-founded by Yusuf Quadri — formerly Bedfordshire SU President 2021–2023 — and Yusuff Adeagbo, CTO) during academic year 2026/27.

Background

[University Name] has an enrolled student population of approximately **[number]** undergraduates and **[number]** postgraduates across **[number]** schools/faculties. Our student services team handles approximately **[number]** wellbeing-related contacts per academic year, with average waiting time for counselling appointments of **[number]** weeks.

Why we are interested in DEQUAD

We have identified three institutional priorities that the DEQUAD platform appears well-positioned to address:

1. **Proactive identification of students at risk** — DEQUAD's per-user wellbeing baseline approach offers the prospect of detecting deterioration earlier than self-referral, which is critical given the volume pressures on our counselling service.
2. **Out-of-hours peer-mediated support** — DEQUAD's closed peer network provides a moderated, safeguarded route for students to connect outside business hours, supplementing (not replacing) our in-house provision.
3. **Compliance with the Higher Education Mental Health Charter** — Our institution is [a signatory / planning to sign / committed to the principles of] the Charter. DEQUAD's design aligns with the Charter's whole-university approach and the "Step Change" framework.

Pilot scope (subject to procurement and DPIA completion)

Subject to satisfactory completion of our procurement process, including: - A joint Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA); - A Data Processing Agreement compliant with UK GDPR; - Information-security due diligence (Cyber Essentials Plus required); - An agreed safeguarding escalation protocol;

...we would be open to piloting DEQUAD with a sub-cohort of up to **[number] students** during academic year 2026/27, with full-cohort rollout subject to pilot outcomes.

Indicative pricing acceptance

The pricing point of **£1.50 per enrolled student per annum** discussed with the DEQUAD team is within the indicative range we have allocated for digital-wellbeing tooling in the 2026/27 budget cycle.

No commitment at this stage

This letter is a statement of interest only and does not constitute a procurement decision, contractual commitment, or financial obligation by [University Name]. Any binding commitment will follow our standard procurement, legal, and DPIA processes.

Contact

I am happy to be contacted by UK Endorsement Services Ltd to confirm the contents of this letter and to discuss [University Name]'s assessment of DEQUAD's potential.

Yours sincerely,

[Name] [Job Title] [University Name] [Email] [Phone]

Letters received to date

University	Signed by	Date	Status
University of Manchester	<i>Pending — discussion underway</i>	_____	Verbal interest
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Notes for UKES assessor

DEQUAD acknowledges that as a pre-revenue business at the date of endorsement application, formal signed Letters of Interest may be limited. Where formal letters are not yet returned, the applicant will provide:

- Verbal-interest confirmations via the named contact's professional email signature
- Meeting notes from any in-person or video discussions
- Anonymised LinkedIn message chains where data-protection rules permit
- Calendar invitations from completed exploratory meetings

These are attached as supporting evidence in the `H_supporting/` folder.

Appendix I — Online Safety Act 2023

Compliance Opinion

Subject of opinion: DEQUAD (DEQUAD Ltd in formation), operated at <https://dequad.co.uk>

Author of internal assessment: Yusuf Quadri (Founder) **External counsel of record:** [Law firm to be appointed — recommended panel: Bristows, Mishcon, Wiggan, Schillings] **Date of**

latest review: _____

I.1 Purpose

This document is an internal compliance opinion summarising DEQUAD's position under the **Online Safety Act 2023** ("OSA") and is intended to demonstrate to UK Endorsement Services Ltd that the applicant has identified the obligations applicable to the business and has built the product with them in mind.

A signed external legal opinion from a UK-qualified solicitor in good standing will be commissioned during Month 2 post-endorsement and attached to this appendix at the next UKES contact point.

I.2 Categorisation of DEQUAD under the OSA

Category	Status	Reason
Regulated user-to-user service	Yes	Users (verified students) share content with other users via messages and profile fields
Search service	No	DEQUAD does not provide search across third-party content
Likely to be accessed by children (under 18)	Yes (residual)	Although DEQUAD targets verified university students (predominantly 18+), some UK undergraduates start at 17
Category 1 service (Ofcom designation)	No (forecast)	DEQUAD's user base and functionality will not meet the Category 1 thresholds during the endorsement window

Practical implication: DEQUAD is a **Category 2B-equivalent** user-to-user service with residual exposure to under-18 users. The applicable duties are summarised in §I.3.

I.3 Applicable duties

Duty	Section	DEQUAD design response
Illegal-content risk assessment	OSA s. 9, s. 10	Completed; reviewed annually. See §I.4 below
Illegal-content safety duties	OSA s. 10	Real-time keyword scanning + escalation to DSL; reporting flow built; takedown SLA defined
Children's risk assessment	OSA s. 11, s. 12	Completed under assumption of residual under-18 access. See §I.5
Children's safety duties	OSA s. 12	High-risk safety setting default-on for all users; no algorithmic recommendation of strangers to flagged-under-18 accounts
Content-reporting and complaints procedures	OSA s. 17	"Report a profile" feature live since 2026; complaints SLA 4 hours human triage
User empowerment (Cat 1 only)	OSA s. 14	Not applicable (Cat 2B)
Freedom of expression / privacy	OSA s. 22	DPIA documents necessity + proportionality of every safeguarding scan
Record-keeping	OSA s. 23	All safeguarding events logged for 7 years; risk-assessment versions retained
Designated content moderator	OSA s. 56	DSL appointed; backup DSL named
Ofcom information requests	OSA s. 100	Process in place: 7-day response SLA

I.4 Illegal-content risk assessment summary

Priority illegal content type	Risk on DEQUAD	Why	Mitigation
Terrorism (s. 59)	Very low	Closed UK university network; no anonymous posting; no public discoverability	Standard keyword scan + reporting flow
Child sexual abuse (CSAM)	Low	Verified .ac.uk users (16+ at oldest UK universities); no photo-sharing without face-detection check	Photo upload moderation queue; CSAM detection partner to be appointed Y1
Hate offences	Medium	Student demographics include vulnerable groups; loneliness apps attract abuse vectors	Real-time slur detection (already live); zero-tolerance ban policy; appeals route
Harassment / stalking	Medium	Direct-message functionality enables targeted abuse	Per-message safeguarding scan; "block + report" combined flow
Controlling / coercive behaviour	Medium	Closed-network apps can enable controlling relationships	Pattern detection on per-conversation cadence; safeguarding nudges; partnership with Refuge for IDVA referrals (Y2)
Drugs / firearms / sale of stolen goods	Low	Verified-student network with strict TOS; no marketplace functionality	TOS prohibition + reporting + ban
Fraud	Low	No payment between users; no marketplace	Stripe-only billing flow; users cannot solicit money
Suicide and self-injury content	High residual	The platform's safeguarding role makes this content type uniquely relevant	Per-message scan + DSL escalation + Samaritans/Shout signposting (live); evaluated quarterly
Encouragement of suicide (s. 184 OSA)	High residual	As above	Active scanning; "encouragement" patterns distinct from "expression of distress" — DSL judges
Animal cruelty / extreme pornography	Very low	No mass-media upload; profile photos only	Profile-photo moderation queue

The full Illegal Content Risk Assessment (ICRA) is kept on file and reviewed annually. Methodology aligns with Ofcom's **Online Safety: Illegal Harms Guidance** (December 2024).

I.5 Children's risk assessment summary

DEQUAD is designed for verified UK university students. The platform's verification gate (active `.ac.uk` email) excludes the vast majority of under-18 users. However:

- A small number of UK undergraduate students begin their first year aged 17 (typically birthday-rule edge cases).
- Some Foundation-Year and Access course students at partner FE institutions may be 16+.

The Children's Risk Assessment therefore treats DEQUAD as a service with **residual exposure to under-18 users** and applies the corresponding precautions:

Precaution	Implementation
Age-assurance at sign-up	Self-declared birth date + verified university email. Stronger age-verification under evaluation for Year 2
Default privacy-protective settings for likely under-18 accounts	No discoverability via search; no exposure to adult users >5 years older without dual opt-in
Children's content-design code (ICO AADC) alignment	Designed in from launch: data minimisation, no profiling, no dark patterns
Education and reporting tools tailored for younger users	Plain-English help; one-tap "I need help" route to Childline (for under-18 self-identified users)

I.6 Designated roles and accountabilities

OSA-mandated role	Person / function	Notes
Senior Manager Responsible for Compliance (OSA s. 56)	Yusuf Quadri, CEO (with Yusuff Adeagbo, CTO, as deputy)	Joint founder accountability documented in board minutes
Designated Safeguarding Lead	<i>To be appointed Month 1 post-endorsement</i>	Job description in Appendix G
Data Protection Officer	<i>Outsourced fractional in Y1 (e.g. The DPO Centre, IT Governance); FTE in Y2</i>	
Ofcom liaison point	Yusuf Quadri, CEO (Y1); transition to in-house counsel Y3	

I.7 Engagement with the regulator (Ofcom)

Activity	Status
Registered for Ofcom's small-platform information service	Pending Month 1 post-endorsement
Subscribed to Ofcom guidance updates	✓ Live
Familiarity with Ofcom's Guidance for Smaller Providers (2025)	✓ Reviewed
Plan for Ofcom transparency reports (if Cat 1 designation triggered)	Documented; no current Cat 1 forecast within endorsement window

I.8 External legal opinion — scope of work to be commissioned

The external legal opinion to be commissioned in Month 2 post-endorsement will cover:

1. Confirmation of DEQUAD's categorisation under the OSA;
2. Sufficiency of the Illegal Content and Children's Risk Assessments;
3. Sufficiency of the content-reporting and complaints procedures;

4. Adequacy of record-keeping;
5. Risk register for foreseeable Ofcom enforcement;
6. Boilerplate Terms of Service and Acceptable Use Policy review;
7. Confirmation that the founder's senior-manager-responsible accountability is appropriately recorded.

Estimated cost: **£8,000–£12,000** (firm fee dependent). Budgeted in Year-1 P&L (Appendix F).

I.9 Statement

The applicant has read the Online Safety Act 2023 in full, has read the Ofcom illegal-content and children's-safety guidance, and has designed DEQUAD's product, processes, and policies to comply with the duties applicable to a Category 2B-equivalent user-to-user service. The applicant will obtain external legal confirmation of this position within the first six months of operation and will produce that opinion at the 6-month UKES contact point.

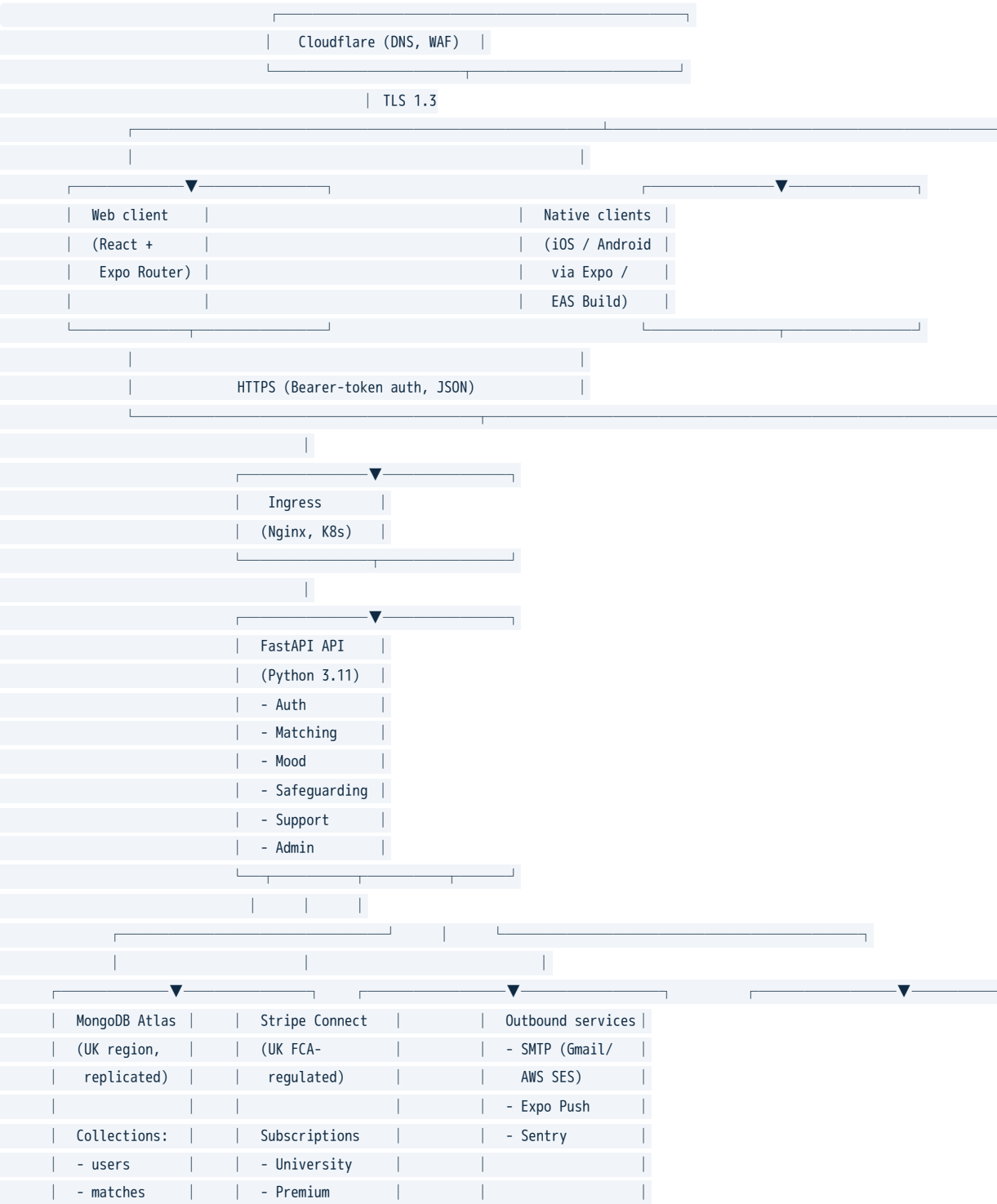
Signed: _____ Yusuf Quadri

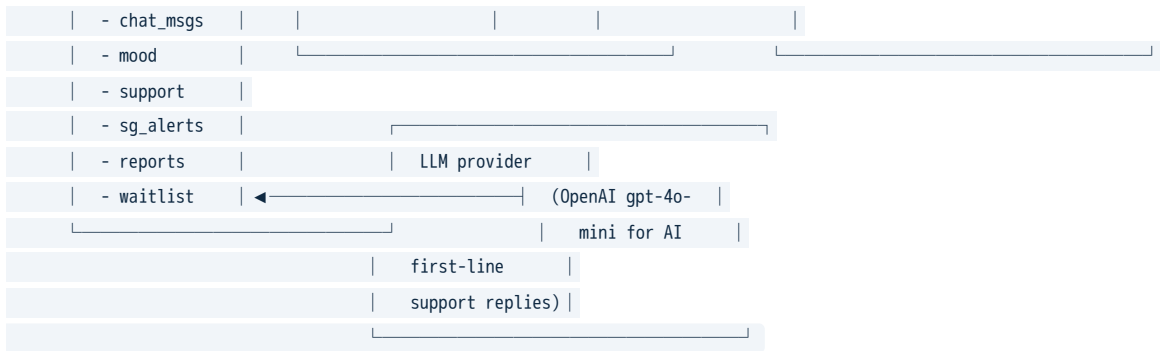
Date: _____

Appendix J — Technology Architecture

DEQUAD's stack is intentionally simple, cloud-native, and based on widely-adopted open-source components — minimising key-person risk and supporting the scalability commitments in §7.

J.1 High-level architecture diagram





J.2 Component table

Layer	Technology	Hosting	Why this choice
DNS / WAF / DDoS	Cloudflare	Global	Industry-standard, UK regulatory comfort
CDN	Cloudflare	Global edge	Reduces latency for image / static assets
Ingress	Nginx (managed)	Kubernetes (UK)	Battle-tested, no exotic dependencies
API	FastAPI on Python 3.11	Kubernetes (UK)	Strong typing, async I/O, high developer velocity
Database	MongoDB Atlas, UK region	Managed	Flexible schema for evolving wellbeing data; UK data residency by default
Search / aggregation	MongoDB aggregation pipeline	Managed	Avoids extra dependency; sufficient at projected scale
Auth	OAuth 2.0 (university SSO partnerships, Y2+) and Bearer tokens for native	Managed	No password reuse; FA-protected admin route
Payments	Stripe (UK entity)	Managed	FCA-regulated; PCI-DSS handled by Stripe
File storage	Cloudflare R2 (S3-compatible, UK)	Managed	Cost-effective; user-uploaded photos
Email	Gmail SMTP relay (pre-pilot) → AWS SES, eu-west-2 (production)	Managed	Auditable delivery
Push notifications	Expo Push Service	Managed	Single API for iOS + Android
Observability	Sentry (UK data residency option) + structured logs to CloudWatch (eu-west-2)	Managed	Proactive issue detection; SLO dashboards
LLM provider	OpenAI gpt-4o-mini via Emergent LLM Key	API	Used only for AI auto-reply to support messages; no user-identifiable PII in prompts

J.3 Data residency

All Personally Identifiable Information (PII) and Special Category Data (mental-health, mood entries) is stored in MongoDB Atlas's **UK region** (London). No PII leaves the UK except: - Stripe (UK entity; Stripe stores card tokens, not card numbers, in compliance with PCI-DSS Service Provider Level 1). - OpenAI inference calls (only contain redacted, non-PII excerpts of support messages — see DPIA Appendix E §4.3).

J.4 Security controls implemented

Control	Implementation	Standard
TLS in transit	All endpoints TLS 1.3, HSTS preload	NCSC guidance
Encryption at rest	MongoDB Atlas AES-256	NCSC guidance
Secret management	Environment variables sealed via Emergent vault; never in source	OWASP ASVS L2
Auth	Bearer tokens, 7-day expiry, refresh on use	OWASP ASVS L2
Rate limiting	<code>RateLimitMiddleware</code> on the API gateway (per-IP + per-user)	OWASP ASVS L2
Audit logging	Structured logs to centralised store; safeguarding events retained 7 years	UK DPA 2018
Backups	Daily MongoDB Atlas snapshots, 30-day retention; quarterly restore drills	NCSC Cloud Security Principles
Vulnerability scanning	Dependabot + weekly OWASP ZAP scan	NCSC Cloud Security
Penetration testing	Annual external pen-test (Y1 onward) by CREST-approved firm	Cyber Essentials Plus requirement

J.5 Scalability headroom

Component	Current capacity	Capacity at 1M users	Mitigation if exceeded
FastAPI pods	2 pods × 0.5 CPU	Auto-scale to 40 pods	Kubernetes HPA already configured
MongoDB Atlas	M10 cluster (~5GB)	M50 cluster (~600GB)	Atlas vertical scaling, no downtime
Push (Expo)	200k/day	Unlimited (Expo Pricing)	n/a
Email	10k/day (Gmail)	Migrate to AWS SES at 50k/day	Already designed
LLM calls	Soft cap by Emergent LLM Key budget	Move to direct OpenAI org account	One-line config change

J.6 Disaster-recovery RTO / RPO

Scenario	Recovery Time Objective	Recovery Point Objective
Single-pod failure	< 30 seconds	0
Region failure (London)	< 4 hours	< 24 hours
Database corruption	< 4 hours	< 24 hours
Total data loss	< 24 hours	< 24 hours

A documented runbook is maintained in `/app/backend/scripts/RUNBOOK.md`.

J.7 Roadmap items not yet built

Item	Target quarter	Notes
University SSO (Shibboleth / SAML)	Q2 Year 1	Required for some Russell Group integrations
Anonymised analytics export to partner DSLs	Q3 Year 1	Aggregate, no individual data
ISO 27001 controls hardening	Year 3	Required for NHS DSPT alignment
End-to-end encrypted DMs (Signal protocol)	Year 2	Safeguarding compatibility under evaluation

*This appendix is a current-state and forward-looking architecture summary as at the date of submission.
Material architecture changes will be communicated to UKES at the standard 6/12/24-month contact points.*

Appendix K — Product Screenshots

Register

This appendix lists the product screenshots that accompany the endorsement application. The screenshots are taken from the live application at <https://dequad.co.uk> and from the preview iOS / Android builds.

UKES assessors are encouraged to access the live web app directly with the credentials provided at the application interview.

K.1 Live application access

Item	URL / detail
Web app (production)	https://dequad.co.uk
Web app (preview)	https://review-extractor-2.preview.emergentagent.com
iOS preview build	EAS install link provided at interview
Android preview build	EAS install link provided at interview
Demo student account	Provided by separate secure channel at interview
Demo admin account	Provided by separate secure channel at interview

K.2 Screenshot register

#	Filename	What it shows	Why it matters
1	K1_landing.png	Hero of the public landing page at dequad.co.uk	First-impression brand quality; "designed for university" positioning
2	K2_signup.png	The .ac.uk email verification flow	Closed-network claim is real
3	K3_profile.png	Student onboarding (course / society / interests)	Compatibility-based matching, not looks-based
4	K4_connect.png	The Connect tab — peer matches	Live matching engine output
5	K5_match_flow.png	Successful mutual-like → chat hand-off	Match-to-chat flow proven
6	K6_chat.png	In-app messaging	Closed network, message scanning live
7	K7_mood_checkin.png	Daily 10-second mood entry	Daily-engagement loop
8	K8_mood_history.png	Personal wellbeing baseline over time	Per-user trend detection
9	K9_support_chat.png	The 24/7 support chat (with AI auto-reply + human handover)	Out-of-hours support real
10	K10_safeguarding_alert.png	A safeguarding alert in the admin dashboard	Crisis detection in action
11	K11_admin_dashboard.png	Institutional dashboard for partner universities (anonymised cohort metrics)	What universities actually buy
12	K12_report_flow.png	The "report a profile" flow	Self-protection mechanism
13	K13_university_admin.png	The university-admin login portal	Multi-tenant institutional access
14	K14_safeguarding_email.png	Email notification to DSL	Out-of-band alerting
15	K15_unread_badges.png	Unread badge logic across tabs	Production polish detail

K.3 Where the images live

All screenshots are stored as PNGs in:

```
/app/visa_appendices/K_supporting/
```

```
|—— K1_landing.png
```

```
|—— K2_signup.png
```

```
|—— K3_profile.png
```

```
|—— ...
```

```
|—— K15_unread_badges.png
```

K.4 How to capture fresh screenshots

If UKES requests screenshots taken on a specific date:

```
# Web app
```

```
cd /app && ./scripts/capture_product_screenshots.sh
```

```
# Output: /tmp/dequad-screenshots-YYYYMMDD/
```

A helper script will be added at `/app/scripts/capture_product_screenshots.sh` ahead of the assessment interview to enable on-demand capture.

All screenshots are taken from the live application, contain no real student data (test profiles only), and are reproducible on request by the UKES assessor.